

CHARLOTTE MUSIC CENSUS



Photos Courtesy of Music Everywhere Charlotte

Summary REPORT
February 2026

 **SOUND MUSIC CITIES**

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Executive Summary

The 2025 Charlotte Music Census was a community-led initiative designed to better understand the strengths and challenges of the local music ecosystem. The Charlotte Music Census launched on October 22, 2025, and ran through November 28, 2025 and collected 1,046 responses from across the creative, industry, and venue/presenter sectors.

Charlotte music ecosystem respondents are predominantly Music Creatives (70%), but healthy representation from Industry (20%) and Venue/Presenter roles (10%). Respondents report high levels of experience (over 10 years in music), reflecting a mature music community.

Creative respondents represent a wide range of roles, including performers, songwriters, educators, producers, and engineers. Top career concerns include rising cost of living and pay rates not keeping pace with expenses, alongside challenges related to sustaining consistent music work. Creative respondents report significant annual spending on their music practice, contributing a collective \$4.7 million in total creative spending each year, with 44% of that staying local.

Industry respondents reflect a diverse set of occupations, led by event and venue workers, music marketing professionals, and music development roles. Venue and Presenter respondents represent a mix of ownership types and facility sizes, with many operating small- to mid-sized spaces. On average, Charlotte venues present 93 live events per venue per year, totaling roughly 5,108 live events annually.

Venues and presenters report navigating a complex regulatory environment, with sound policy, permitting processes, and regulatory confusion ranking among the most impactful challenges. Respondents express strong interest in tools that improve clarity and coordination, including a centralized live music regulations webpage, a single point of contact, and tiered compliance approaches. When asked about financial assistance, venue and presenter respondents most often prefer microgrants and tax-based incentives.

Music-related income represents a meaningful but limited share of overall earnings for many respondents. Across all respondents, music activity generates an estimated \$31 million in annual income, with respondents reporting that an average of 30% of their total annual income comes from music-related work. Average household income among respondents is \$99,000, while average annual income derived specifically from music is \$29,000. A majority work outside of music to supplement income, and median pay for performances remains low. These dynamics highlight the importance of workforce development, income stability, and clearer career pathways. Respondents most frequently identify marketing (53%), audio and video recording or engineering (50%), and booking, promotion, and event production (49%) as priority skill areas, pointing to demand for practical, career-sustaining workforce support.

Charlotte respondents identify connection and collaboration as priorities for strengthening the music ecosystem. Preferences include better access to music services, opportunities to collaborate, stronger audience development, and greater integration of local music into public spaces and community life.

The Charlotte music ecosystem is widely viewed as safe, inclusive, and welcoming, but respondents also describe underlying tension around elitism and ageism.

The Charlotte music community demonstrates a sense of pride and a desire for more connection and community. This report and the online dashboard available at <https://charlottemusiccensus.org/> provides a foundation for continued community dialogue and informed action to support Charlotte's music ecosystem and its cultural and economic contributions.

Introduction

The Charlotte Music Census is a community-led initiative organized to gain a better understanding of the current strengths, opportunities and needs of the Charlotte ecosystem. The Charlotte Music Census captures key information to help the Charlotte music community as well as local and regional policymakers make better informed, data-driven decisions to support our music ecosystem moving forward.

The 2025 Charlotte Music Census ran from October 22, 2025 – November 28, 2025 and collected 1046 responses. The study was open to all people working in music in any capacity (paid or unpaid) who are 18 years or older and living in Mecklenburg County, or who identify as part of the Charlotte Music ecosystem. The census was administered by Sound Music Cities, a leading Austin-based provider of music ecosystem studies and music census work, in conjunction with Music Everywhere CLT. Charlotte is part of the 2025-2026 multi-city cohort program administered by Sound Music Cities which meets monthly to discuss best practices on improving music ecosystems, allowing Charlotte to gain insight from other cities conducting similar research.

This report has been prepared by Sound Music Cities and includes an overview of the Music Ecosystem Health Assessment based on 10 key indicator areas. The report includes key findings and recommendations. Alongside this report, Sound Music Cities has provided access to an online dashboard where you can find more data at <https://charlottesmusiccensus.org/>.

INTRODUCTION TO A MUSIC CENSUS

Any strategy to support and grow a music ecosystem begins with a basic understanding of its population. Professional music communities are not easily discoverable using traditional methods (such as through labor statistics or economic data). A music census collects key data points to better understand music people and their economic activity within a specific geography. It provides a baseline for policymakers and the larger community to understand and take action.

The value of a music census goes well beyond the data itself. Such initiatives ignite a range of activities that are conducive to more strategic and sustainable support for local music scenes over the long term, beginning with validating this economically marginalized group, sharing new learning, activating civic and community resources, and ultimately empowering music people to take ownership of change initiatives.

1046 responses

October 22– November 28, 2025

10% venue/presenter

20% industry

70% music creatives



Photos Courtesy of Music Everywhere Charlotte

A Community Effort

The 2025 study was led by a group of Lead Partners in collaboration with Community Partners. This study took a grassroots approach that engaged local partners who hold the relationships with music people. Community Partners served as the primary means of outreach to music people and these organizations were instrumental in shaping the Census itself. As this report is rolled out, the Lead Partners look forward to welcoming more community partners into this effort going forward.

Thank you to our amazing Lead Partners and Community Partners.

LEAD PARTNERS

Arts & Science Council

Charlotte Center City Partners

Charlotte Is Creative

Charlotte Regional Visitors Authority

FAIR PLAY Music Equity Initiative

Knight Foundation

Music Everywhere Charlotte

Tosco Music

COMMUNITY PARTNERS

Arts+
BACKSPINZ ACADEMY
Captain Chrispy
Charlotte Center City Partners
Charlotte Symphony Orchestra
Chillington Dutch
CRVA
Danny Gassaway
David Cortello
Emily Shonts
found.ee - a Downtown Music Company
Jack
Jambox
La Casa de la Cultura
Laura Toscano
Mariah Van Kleef
Mark Larson Music
Mesa Contracts
Mimi V
rBeatz.com Boutique Radio & Media Streaming Network
Sam on Someday
Sector On Tap
ShotbyK7ven
Sonorous Wave, LLC
Southside Watt
Storytellers.
The Platform/J Spencer
UNC Charlotte Department of Music
VAPA Center
VisArt, Inc
Vocana
We Rock Charlotte
WSGE
Zach Edwards

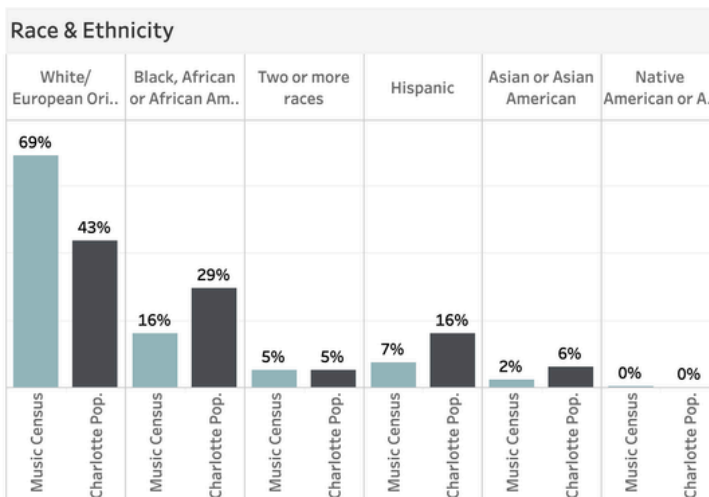
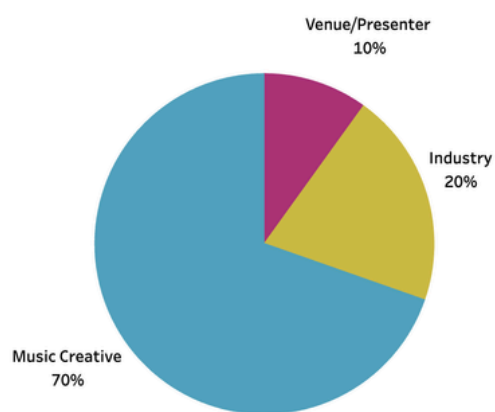


Photos Courtesy of Music Everywhere Charlotte

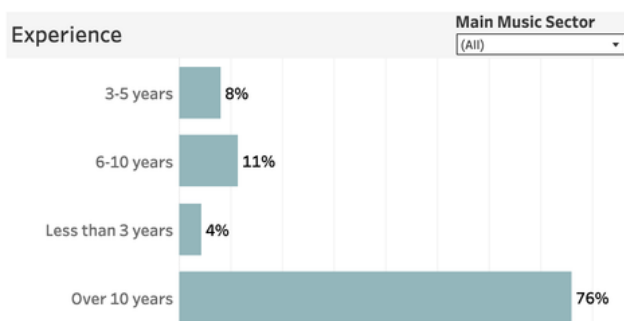
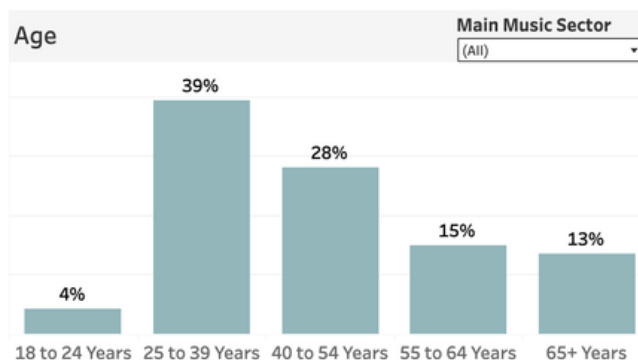
Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Ecosystem Composition

The Charlotte music ecosystem respondents are predominantly Music Creatives (70%), with smaller, but healthy representation from Industry (20%) and Venue/Presenter roles (10%). The ecosystem reflects a highly experienced workforce, with most respondents reporting over ten years of experience in music. A majority of respondents identify as male and White/European Origin, and participation is strongest among mid-career professionals. Notably, gender is more balanced for Industry than Creatives, and in Venues/Presenters, people who identify as female are dominant. The Charlotte ecosystem identifies with many genres, especially Rock (19%), Pop (18%), and Jazz/Blues (13%). North Carolina's Triangle (41%) and Triad (38%) areas are the places most traveled to outside of Charlotte for music-related work.

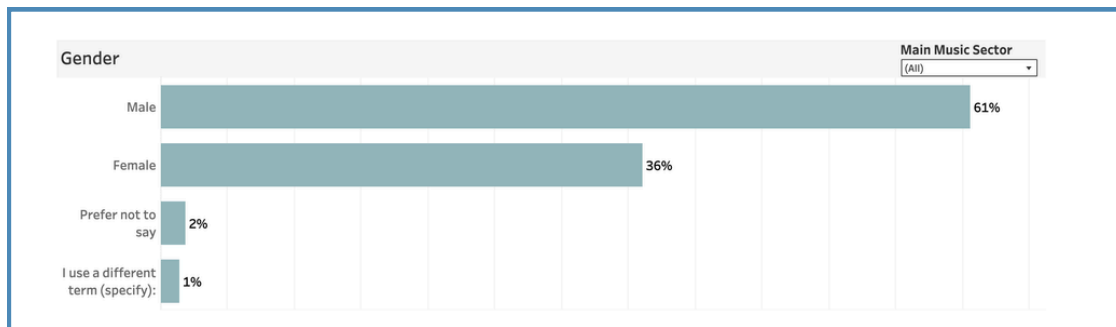


- Race & Ethnicity** - Respondent data shows that 69% of Charlotte music census participants identify as White/European Origin and 16% as Black/African American. An additional 5% identify as Two or More Races, 7% as Hispanic, 2% as Asian or Asian American, 0% as Native American or Alaska Native, and 1% who preferred not to say. Compared to the Charlotte general population, the census reflects higher representation among White/European Origin respondents and lower representation among Black/African American and Hispanic respondents.
- Age** - Respondents span a wide range of ages, with the largest share between 25 and 39 years (39%), followed by those aged 40 to 54 (28%). Individuals aged 55 to 64 account for 15%, and those 65 and older represent 13% of respondents. Younger individuals aged 18 to 24 are underrepresented, making up 4% of the ecosystem respondents.
- Experience** - Overall, 76% of respondents report over ten years of experience working in music, indicating a highly seasoned professional base. Another 11% report 6 to 10 years of experience, 8% report 3 to 5 years, and 4% report less than 3 years, suggesting relatively limited participation from early-career professionals.

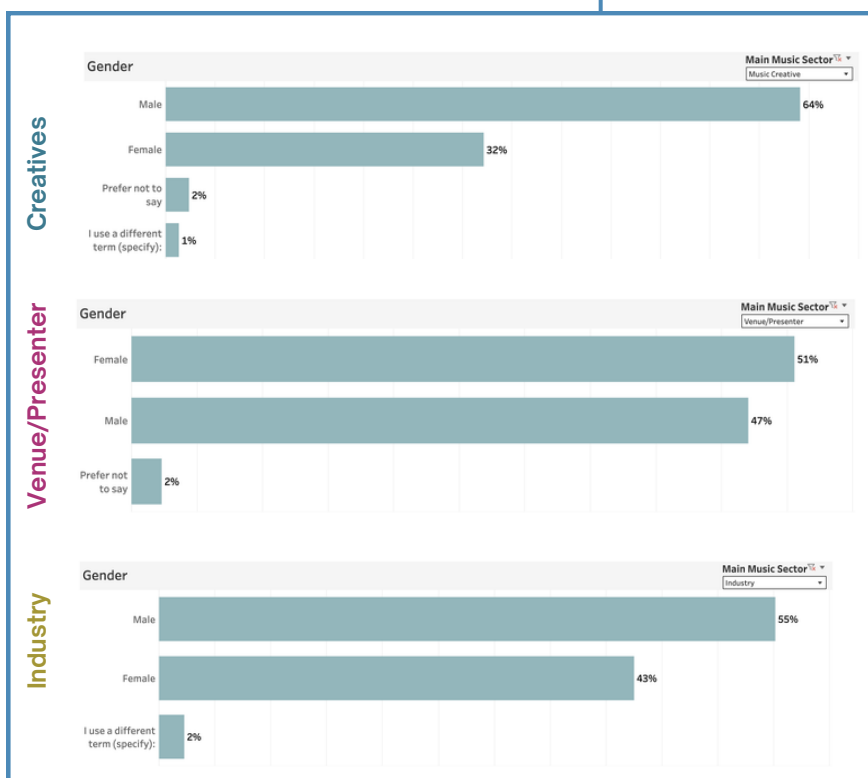


Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Ecosystem Composition (continued 2/4)



- Gender** - Most respondents identify as male (61%), followed by female (36%). An additional 2% prefer not to say, and 1% report using a different term to describe their gender identity. While the music ecosystem overall reflects a male-dominated space, the gender gap improves in the Industry and notably, flips in the Venue/Presenter sector, where female representation is higher.
- Sexual Orientation** - The majority of respondents identify as heterosexual or straight (78%). Nine percent prefer not to say, while 6% identify as bisexual and 5% as gay or lesbian. Smaller shares identify as something else (2%) or asexual (1%).

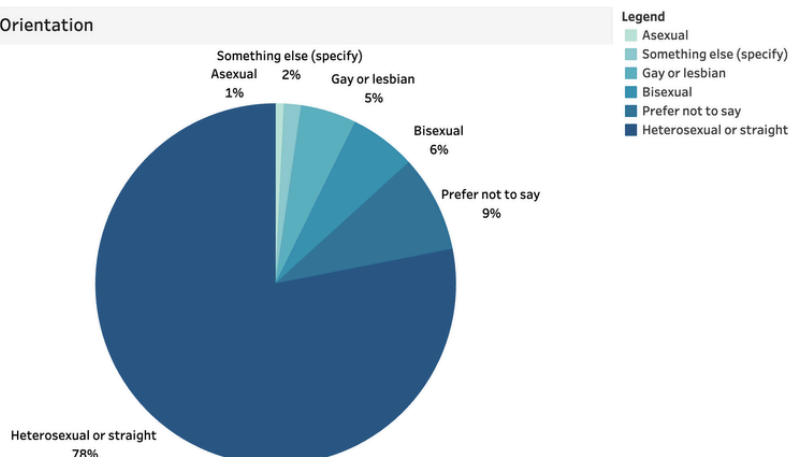


The people that make up the Charlotte music scene are incredible humans.

Scene feels splintered. Wish there were more common physical places for collaboration.

Sense of community and the relationships within the music scene.

Sexual Orientation

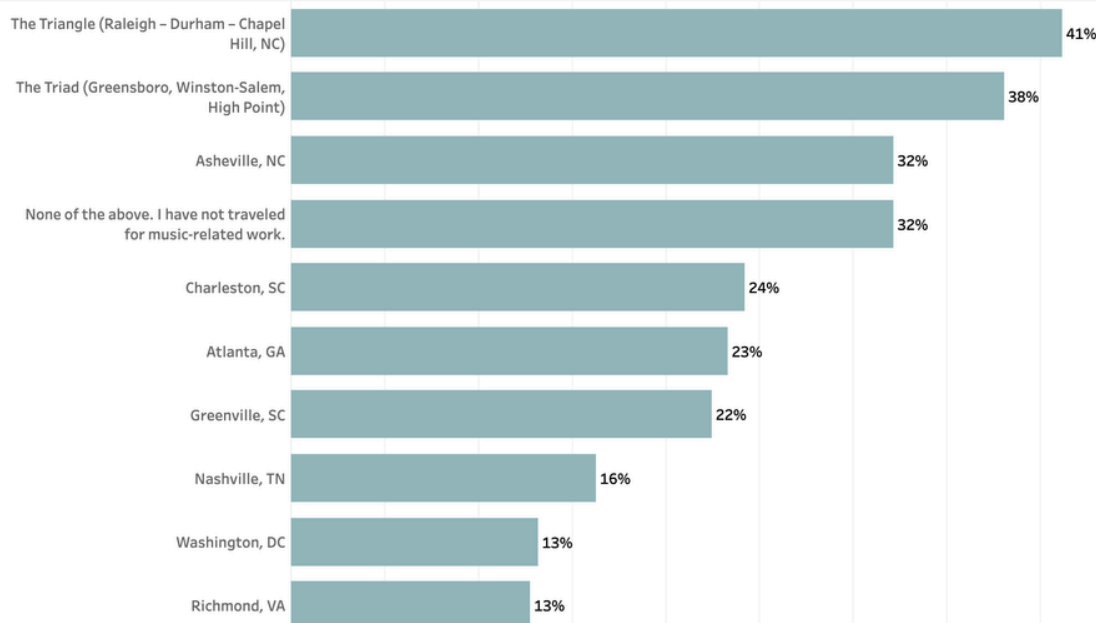


Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Ecosystem Composition (continued 3/4)

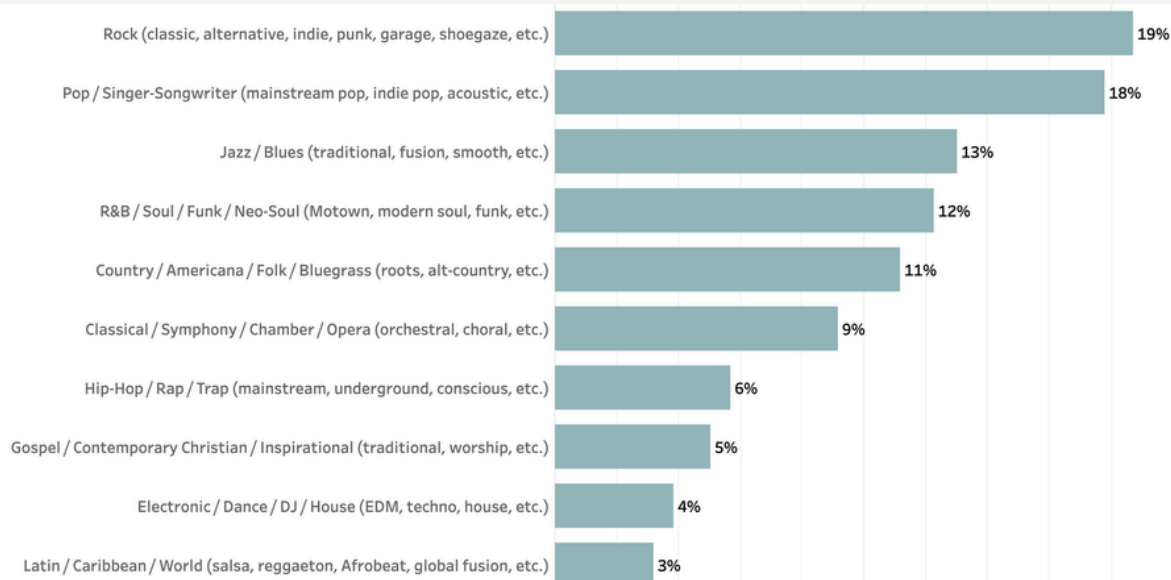
- **Cities Traveled to for Music-Related Work** - Respondents reported traveling primarily within the Southeast for music-related work. The most commonly cited destinations include the Triangle region of North Carolina (41%), the Triad (38%), and Asheville, NC (32%). Nearly one-third of respondents (32%) reported not traveling for music-related work in the past year. Other frequently mentioned destinations include Charleston, SC (24%), Atlanta, GA (23%), Greenville, SC (22%), Nashville, TN (16%), Washington, DC (13%), and Richmond, VA (13%).

Which cities have you traveled to for music-related work in the past year? Select all that apply



- **Genre Identification** - Respondents identify with a wide range of musical genres. The most commonly selected genres include Rock (19%) and Pop/Singer-Songwriter (18%), followed by Jazz/Blues (13%), R&B/Soul/Funk/Neo-Soul (12%), and Country/Americana/Folk/Bluegrass (11%). Classical/Symphony/Chamber/Opera represents 9% of respondents, while Hip-Hop/Rap/Trap (6%), Gospel/Contemporary Christian (5%), Electronic/Dance/DJ/House (4%), and Latin/Caribbean/World (3%) reflect additional stylistic diversity within the ecosystem.

Which genre(s) do you most identify with in your music-related work or role? Select up to three



Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Ecosystem Composition (continued 4/4)

Plans to Stay in Music and in the Charlotte Region:

- Creatives** - The majority of Creative respondents express strong confidence about continuing to work in music over the next three years, with 75% responding “Definitely Yes” and 18% responding “Probably Yes.” Confidence about remaining in Charlotte is slightly lower, with 46% indicating “Definitely Yes” and 33% “Probably Yes,” while 12% report “Possibly Yes,” suggesting some uncertainty about long-term residency despite continued commitment to music careers.
- Venue/Presenter** - Venue and Presenter respondents also report high confidence about continuing to work in music, with 59% responding “Definitely Yes” and 30% “Probably Yes.” Plans to remain in Charlotte are more mixed, with 57% indicating “Definitely Yes” and 24% “Probably Yes,” while 14% report “Possibly Yes,” reflecting moderate uncertainty about remaining in the city.
- Industry** - Industry respondents show strong commitment to continuing work in music, with 51% responding “Definitely Yes” and 31% “Probably Yes.” Confidence about staying in Charlotte is somewhat lower, with 47% reporting “Definitely Yes” and 30% “Probably Yes,” while 16% indicate “Possibly Yes,” suggesting moderate uncertainty in terms of continued engagement in the music profession alongside some uncertainty about long-term residency.



“The community. We really do look out for each other and support each other in our own ways.”

“It’s a tight community when you find your people.”

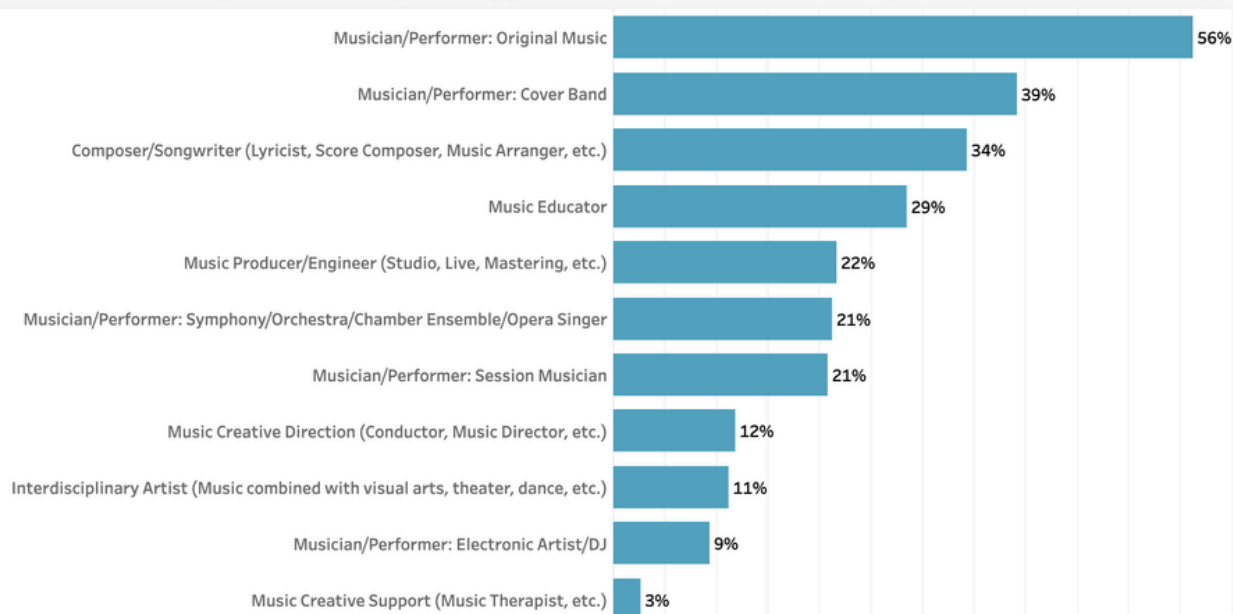
“Very little connectivity between genres.”

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Creative Profile

Creative respondents in Charlotte report taking on a wide range of roles across the local music ecosystem, most commonly as musicians and performers of original music (56%) and cover bands (39%), followed by composers and songwriters (34%), music educators (29%), and producers or engineers (22%). Survey responses indicate a highly experienced creative community, with 84% of respondents reporting more than 10 years of experience. Top career concerns identified by Creative respondents include the rising cost of living and pay rates not keeping pace, with lack of consistent music work also cited as a significant concern. On average, Creative respondents report spending \$6,667 annually on their music careers, contributing a collective \$4.7 million in total creative spending each year, with 44% of those expenses paid locally.

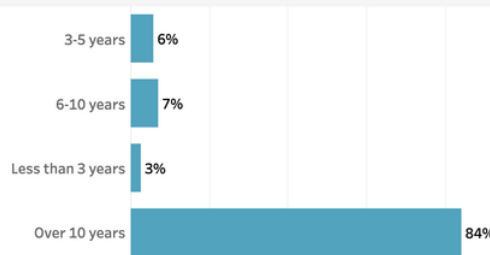
Which of the following best describes your role(s) as a Creative within the music ecosystem? Please select all that apply.



- Creative Types/Roles** - Creative respondents in Charlotte report working in multiple roles within the music ecosystem. The most common roles include musician or performer of original music (56%) and cover band performer (39%), followed by composer or songwriter (34%), music educator (29%), and music producer or engineer (22%). Additional roles reported include symphony, orchestra, chamber ensemble, or opera performers (21%), session musicians (21%), music creative directors such as conductors or music directors (12%), and interdisciplinary artists combining music with other art forms (11%). Smaller segments of respondents identify as electronic artists or DJs (9%) and music creative support roles (3%).
- Experience** - Survey responses show that Charlotte's creative workforce is notably experienced, with 84% of creative respondents reporting more than 10 years of experience in the music industry. Smaller shares of respondents report 6 to 10 years (7%), 3 to 5 years (6%), or less than 3 years (3%) of experience, reflecting a largely established creative community.

“
So many
talented
musicians and
songwriters in
this city.
”

Experience - Creatives

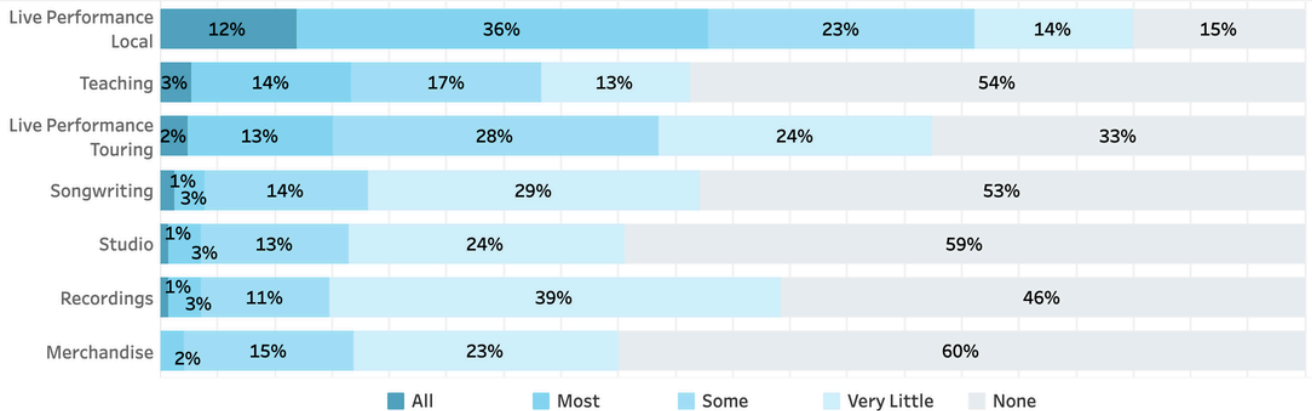


Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Creative Profile (continued 2/3)

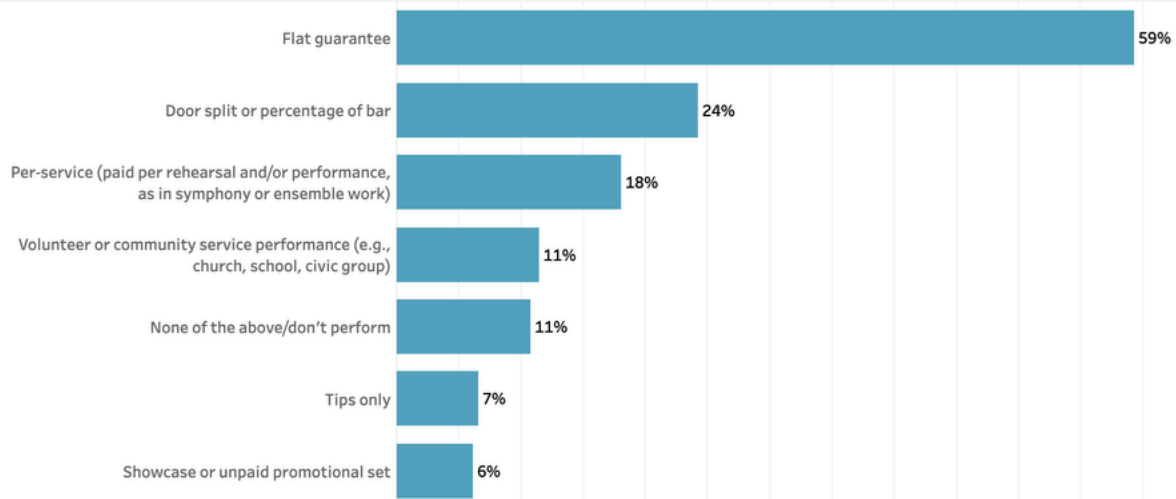
- Sources of Income** - Creative respondents rely primarily on local live performance as their main source of music income. Nearly half of Creative respondents (48%) report earning most or all of their music income from local live performance, making it the strongest income source in the local ecosystem. Teaching serves as a secondary income stream, while touring performance plays a more limited role, with 43% reporting little or no touring income. Income from songwriting, studio work, recordings, and merchandise is largely supplemental.

Creative: Sources of Income



- Local Performance Pay Structure** - When asked about local performance compensation, creative respondents most commonly report being paid through flat guarantees (59%), followed by door splits or a percentage of bar sales (24%). Per-service payment structures, such as rehearsal or performance fees common in ensemble or symphony work, are reported by 18% of respondents. Smaller shares report volunteer or community service performances (11%), unpaid or showcase performances (6%), or tips-only compensation (7%).

Which of these best describes how your local performances are typically paid? (Select up to 2)



“ There are a lot of good open mics and venues with live music. ”

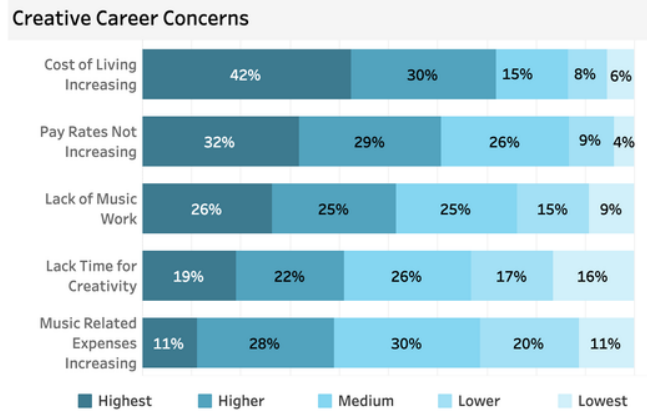
“ There are so few opportunities for talented performers. ”

“ It's hard to turn talent into sustainable work. ”

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Creative Profile (continued 3/3)

- **Career Concerns** - Cost of living increases are the most pressing concern for Creative respondents, with 42% ranking it as their highest concern and an additional 30% as higher, meaning nearly three-quarters view it as a top issue. Pay rates not increasing follows closely, with 32% ranking it highest and 29% higher. Lack of music work is also significant, cited as a highest or higher concern by 51% of respondents. Concerns around time for creativity and rising music-related expenses are more evenly distributed, indicating broader but less acute pressure points across the creative workforce.



Creative Spend

\$6,667

Average Creative Spend

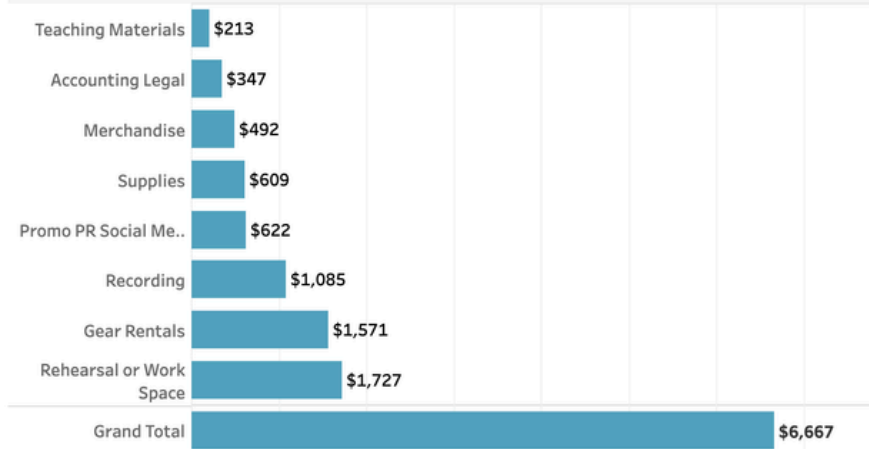
\$4.7M

Total Creative Respondents Spend Annually

44%

Spent Locally

Creative Expenses Annually - Average



Creative Spend - Creative respondents report spending an average of \$6,667 annually on music-related expenses, including rehearsal or workspace, gear rentals, recording, promotion, supplies, and professional services. Based on respondent averages, this represents approximately \$4.7 million in total annual creative spending. Respondents also indicate that 44% of these expenses are paid to local providers, reinforcing the role of creatives as contributors to Charlotte's local economy.

“ Many creatives feel stuck at the same level. ”

“ Original gigs don't pay. ”

“ Energy isn't spent being creative because musicians have to gig constantly to survive. ”

“ The sheer number of places that hire live music around CLT is vastly higher than it's ever been ”

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Venue/Presenter Profile

Venue and Presenter respondents in Charlotte represent a diverse mix of locally owned for-profit, nonprofit, and informal performance spaces, collectively supporting a high volume of live music activity each year. Venue and Presenter respondents identify as live music venues (29%), PAC/Theater (18%), and others that span a broad range of audience capacities. Respondents report hosting an average of 93 live music events per venue annually, totaling approximately 5,108 live events per year, underscoring the scale and consistency of Charlotte's live music infrastructure.

Venues average

93

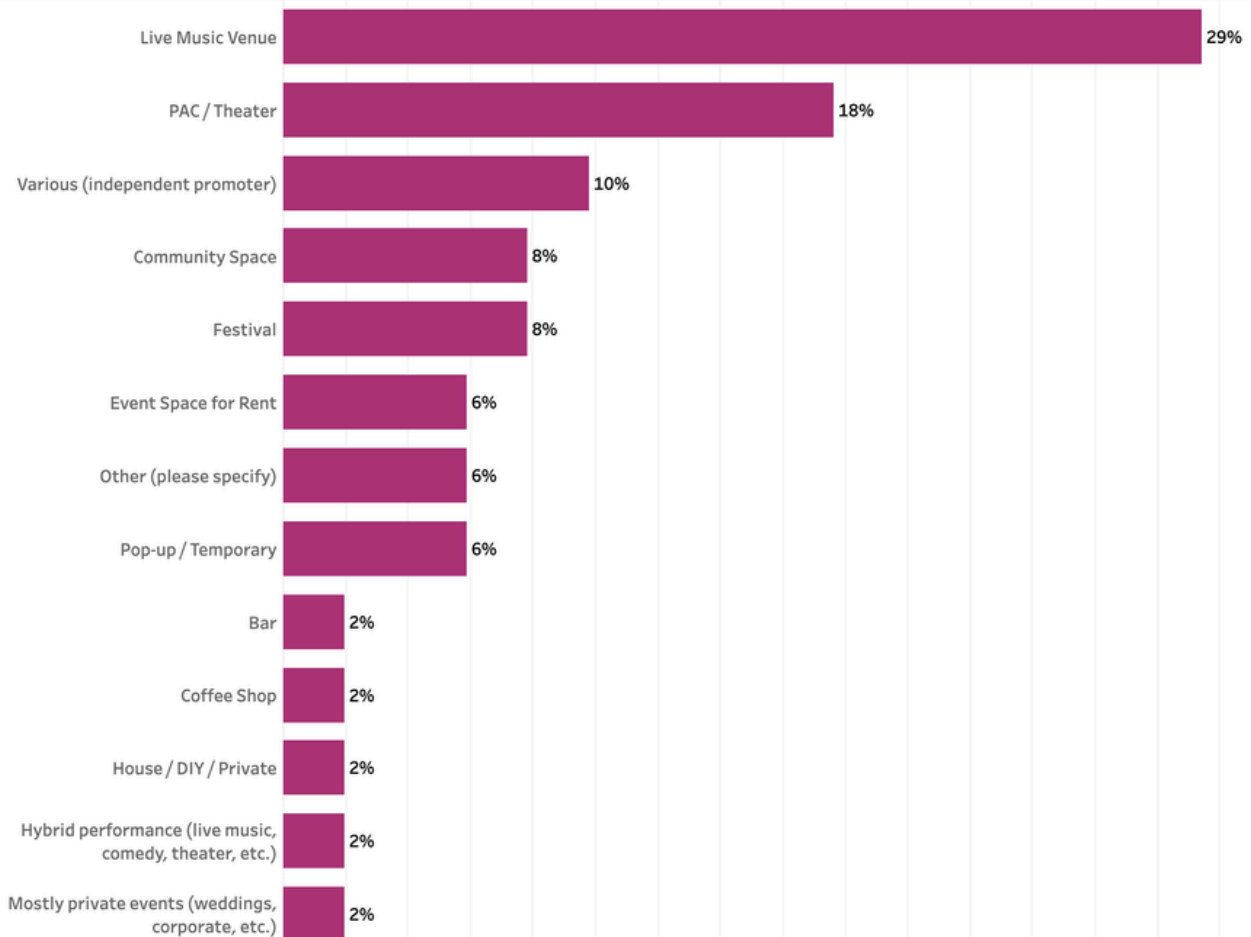
live events/year

5,108

total live events/year

- **Venue Live Events Each Year** – Venue and Presenter respondents report an average of 93 live events per venue per year, resulting in an estimated 5,108 total live music events annually across surveyed venues and presenters. This reflects a steady level of programming activity and highlights the role venues play as year-round cultural anchors.
- **Venue/Presenter Type** - Venue and Presenter respondents represent a wide range of operating models. Live music venues make up the largest share of respondents (29%), followed by performing arts centers and theaters (18%) and independent promoters (10%). Additional respondents include community spaces (8%), festivals (8%), event spaces for rent (6%), pop-up or temporary venues (6%), and smaller shares of bars, coffee shops, house or DIY venues, and hybrid performance spaces (each 2%). This mix points to a decentralized and flexible live music ecosystem.

Venue/Presenter Type



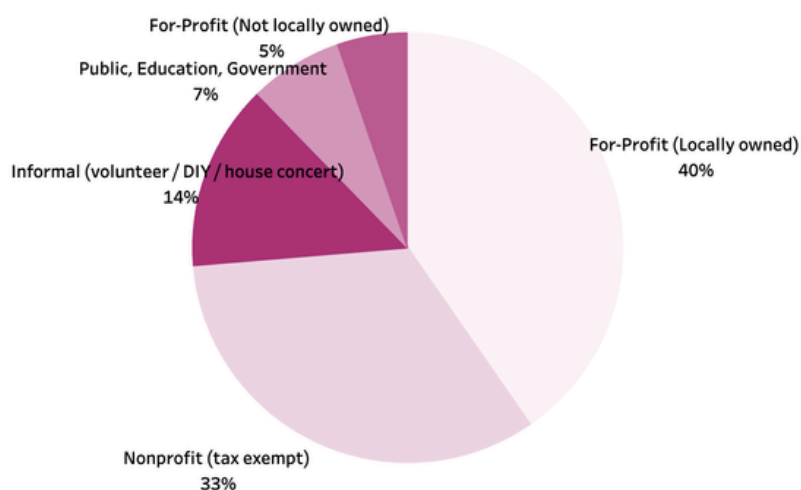
Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Venue/Presenter Profile (continued 2/3)

• Venue Ownership/Tax Structure -

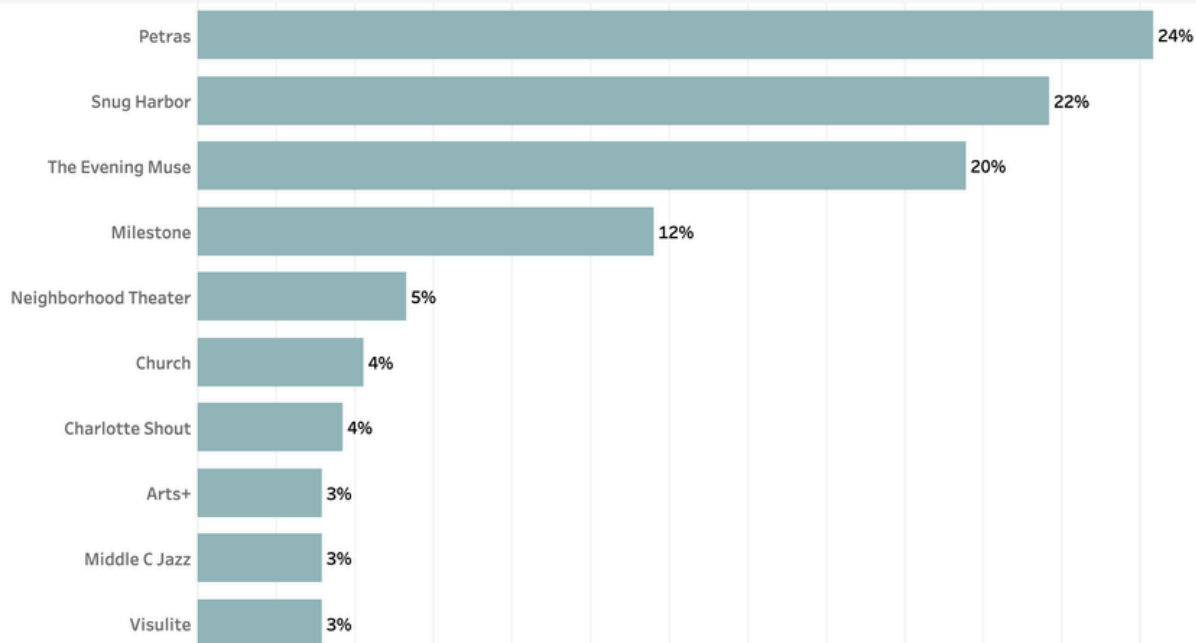
Respondents report a varied ownership landscape. For-profit, locally owned venues account for 40% of venue and presenter respondents, while nonprofit, tax-exempt organizations represent 33%. An additional 14% operate as informal or volunteer-led spaces, including DIY and house concert models. Public, education, or government-affiliated venues make up 7% of respondents, while 5% are for-profit but not locally owned. This distribution highlights the importance of both nonprofit and locally rooted ownership models in sustaining live music activity.

Venue/Presenter Ownership (Tax) Structure



- **Venues with the Best Environment for Performers** - Creative respondents named venues, presenters and festivals where they felt most supported by writing in the names of those places. Petras was the favorite (24%), while Snug Harbor (22%) and The Evening Muse (20%) followed closely. Other favorites included Milestone (12%), Neighborhood Theater (5%), Church (4%), Charlotte Shout (4%), Arts+ (3%), Middle C Jazz (3%) and Visulite (3%).

Which music venues, presenters, or festivals provide the most support and best environment for you or your students to perform? Please list up to 3. Top 10 answers shown.

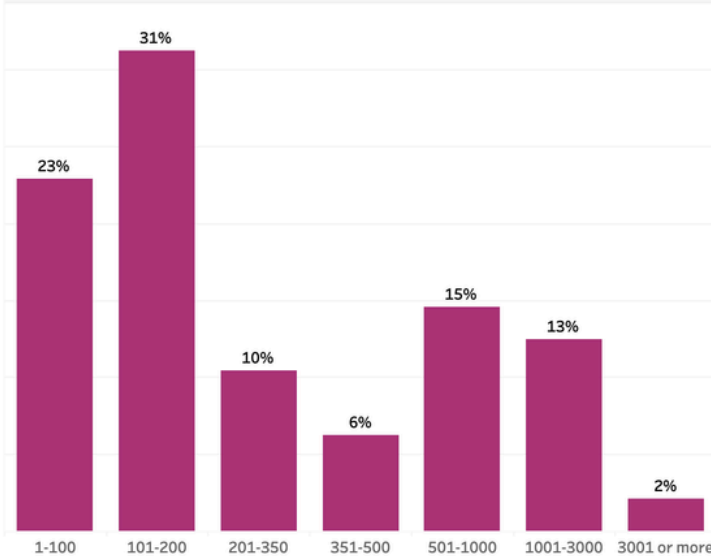


Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

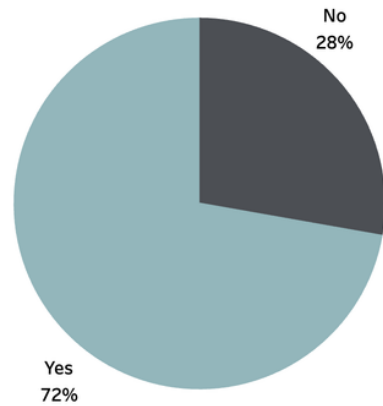
Venue/Presenter Profile (continued 3/3)

- **Venue Capacity & Outdoor Capabilities** - Venue and presenter respondents span a broad range of audience capacities. The largest share report capacities of 101–200 (31%), followed by 1–100 (23%), 501–1,000 (15%), and 1,001–3,000 (13%). Smaller shares report capacities of 201–350 (10%), 351–500 (6%), and 3,001 or more (2%). In addition, 72% of venue respondents report having outdoor performance capabilities, while 28% do not, indicating a strong base for outdoor and flexible programming options across the city.

Venue Capacity - Owner



Outdoor Capabilities



“

I enjoy that Charlotte has a wide array of venues in the area, big and small.

”

“

Multiple venues of varying size.

”

“

Need more mid-tier opera and musical theater companies.

”

“

Venues expect the artist to handle all promotion and marketing.

”

“

Not enough venues for upcoming and local acts.

”

“

Not enough venues for someone under 21.

”

“

Many venues don't have adequate PA systems, monitors, or sound engineers.

”

“

Lack of regular venue access for the symphony.

”

“

Not enough worthwhile places for solo songwriters to perform.

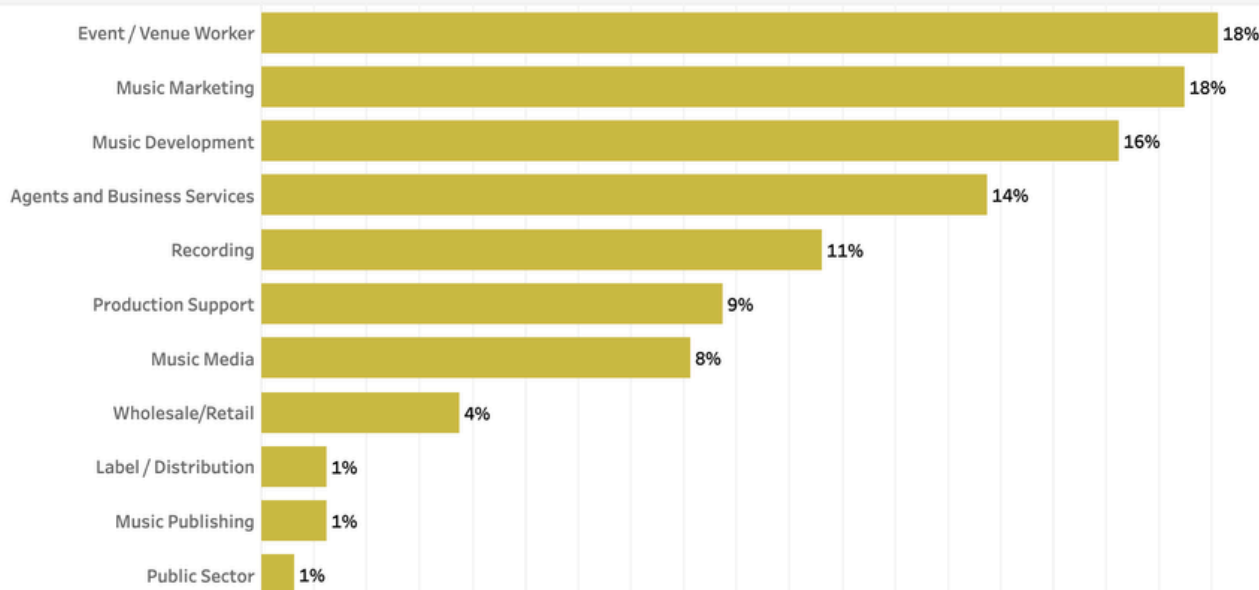
”

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Industry Profile

Industry respondents in Charlotte represent a diverse and multi-functional music industry workforce, led by event and venue workers (18%) and music marketing professionals (18%), followed by music development (16%) and agents and business services (14%). Respondents report a relatively balanced gender distribution, with 55% identifying as male, 43% as female, and 2% using a different term. Access to industry services relies heavily on self-management, particularly for booking (63%), management (60%), and publicity and social media (72%), while locally sourced services are most common for studios (37%) and legal or accounting services (31%). Industry respondents primarily serve local clients, with additional national and limited international reach.

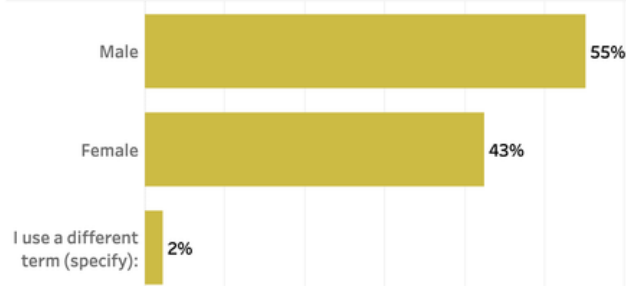
Industry Current Occupation



- **Industry Occupation** - Industry respondents report working across a wide range of music-related roles. The most commonly reported occupations include event and venue workers (18%) and music marketing professionals (18%), followed by music development (16%) and agents and business services (14%). Additional roles include recording (11%), production support (9%), and music media (8%). Smaller shares of respondents report working in wholesale or retail (4%), label or distribution (1%), music publishing (1%), and the public sector (1%), reflecting a broad but fragmented industry workforce.

- **Gender** – Industry respondents in Charlotte report a relatively balanced gender distribution, with 55% identifying as male, 43% as female, and 2% using a different term. The Industry sector shows greater balance in gender, suggesting a healthier gender dynamic within Charlotte's music industry workforce.

Gender - Industry

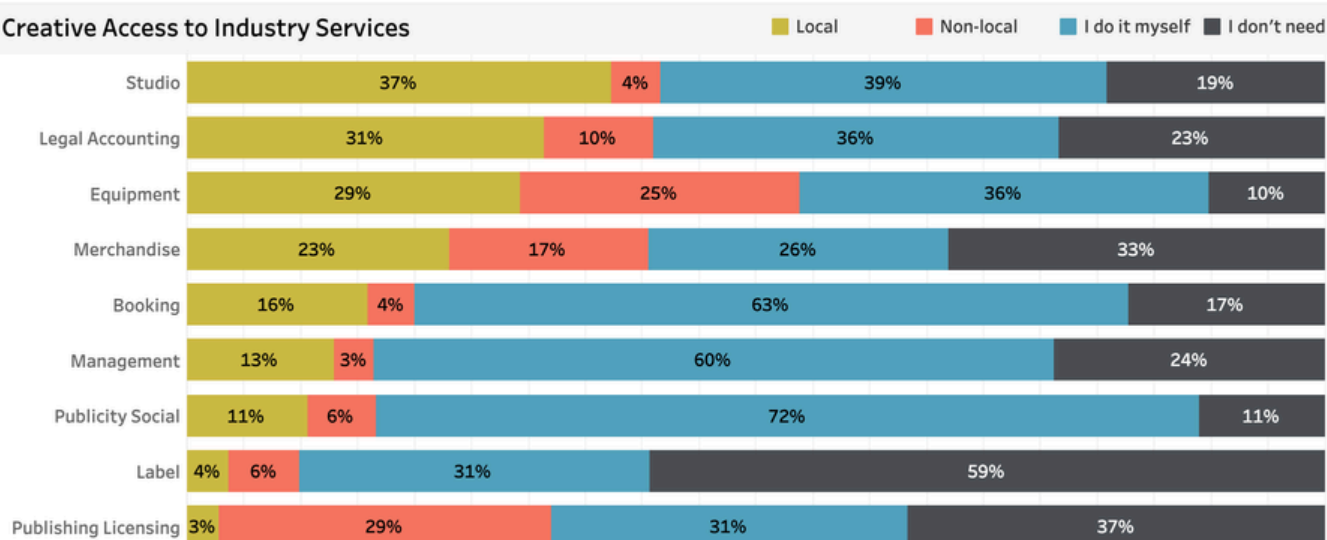


Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Industry Profile (continued)

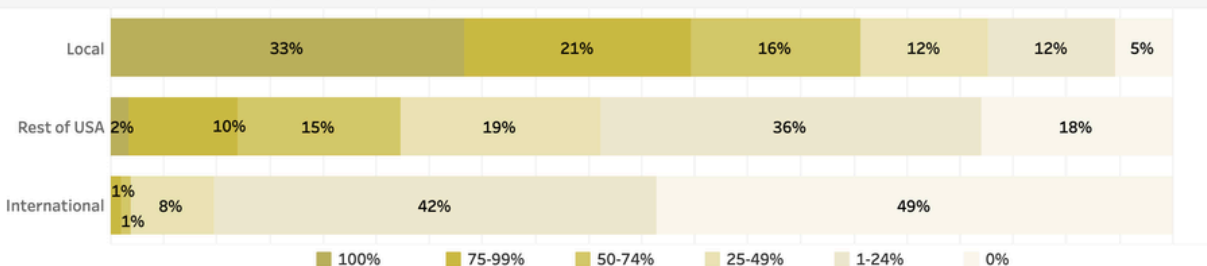
- **Creative Access to Industry** - Industry respondents access services through a mix of local providers, non-local providers, self-management, and opting out. Local services are most commonly used for studios (37%), legal and accounting (31%), and equipment (29%). However, a significant share of respondents report managing services themselves, particularly for publicity and social media (72%), booking (63%), and management (60%). For several services, including labels and publishing/licensing, many respondents report not needing these services at all.

Creative Access to Industry Services



- **Location of Clients** - Charlotte industry professionals primarily serve local clients. Across the majority of the Industry client base, 70% are local, 27% are national, and 2% are international. This highlights a strong local focus as well as some national clients and a few international.

Location of Clients Served by Music Industry



There's no real industry here — everyone is doing everything themselves.

Providing services that can help artist and creators become educated on the music business.

Scene is limited with a small industry community.

No industry here. Rent hikes push studio spaces out.

The industry feels thin and disconnected.

People wear too many hats because there isn't enough infrastructure.

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Economic Activity

Across all respondents, music activity generates an estimated **\$31 million** in annual income, with respondents reporting that an average of **30%** of their total annual income comes from music-related work. Average household income among respondents is **\$99,000**, while average annual income derived specifically from music is **\$29,000**, underscoring the continued reliance on non-music

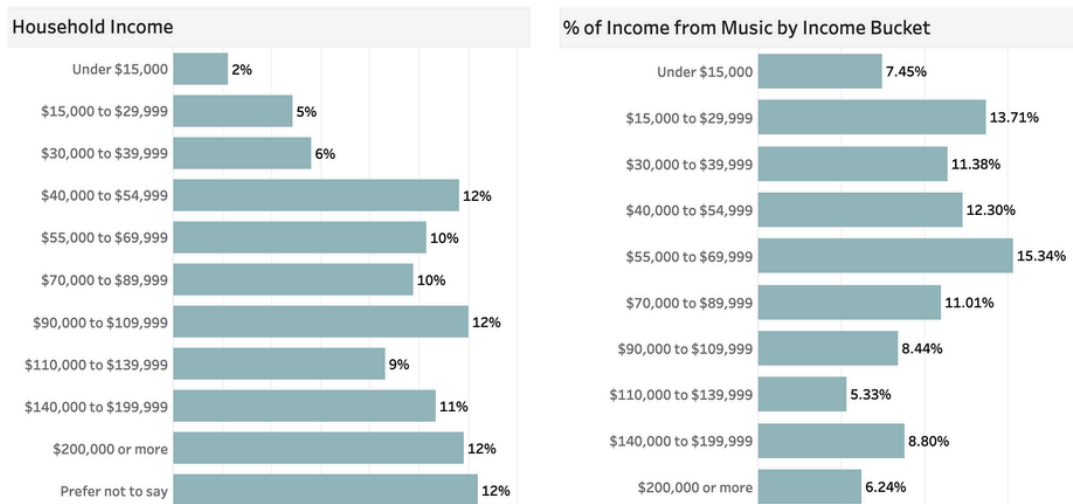
income to support music careers. The data reflects a predominantly freelance and independent workforce, with many respondents working outside of music for income stability, benefits, and flexibility. Local performance remains a primary source of earned income with an average pay of **\$505/performance**, and touring activity is limited for many respondents, contributing to a median touring pay of **\$200**. Creative respondents continue to reinvest significantly in the local music economy, spending an estimated **\$4.7 million** collectively each year on music-related expenses, with **44%** of that spending occurring locally.

Music generates a total of **\$31M** in income annually across all respondents

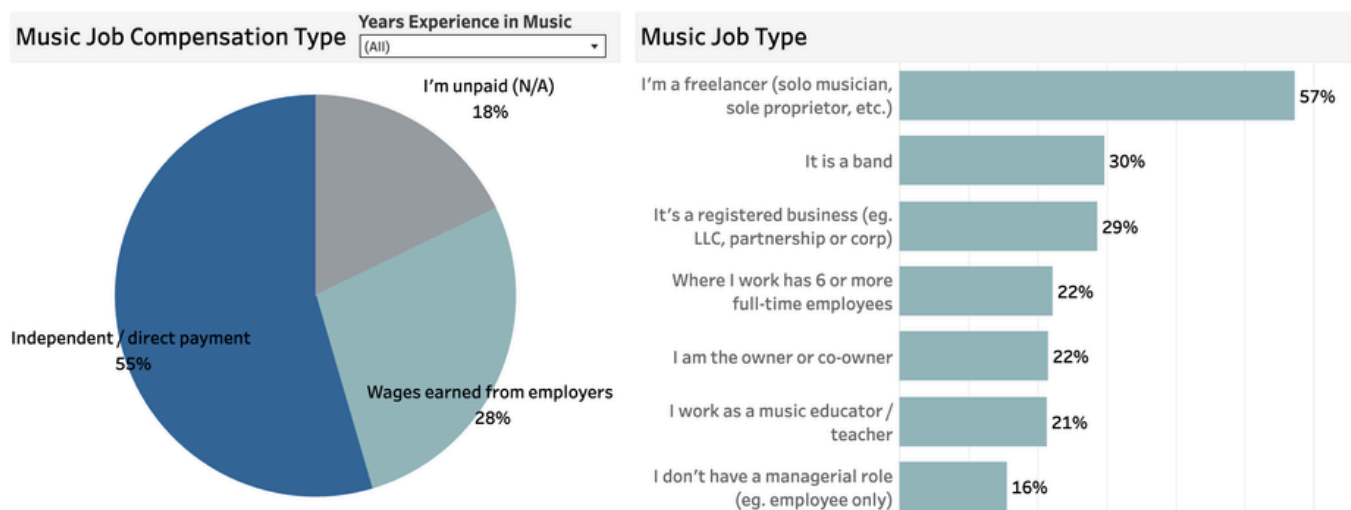
30% of respondent annual income comes from music

Average household income for respondents is **\$99K**

Average annual income from music is **\$29K/respondent**



- Music Job Type/Compensation** - Respondents primarily report working as independent or freelance music workers. Over half (57%) indicate earning income through independent or direct payment, while 27% report earning wages from an employer. An additional 16% report being unpaid for their music work, reflecting the continued prevalence of uncompensated labor within the local music ecosystem. The majority of respondents identify as freelancers or sole proprietors (57%), with others working as part of bands (30%) or registered businesses (29%), underscoring the entrepreneurial nature of music work.

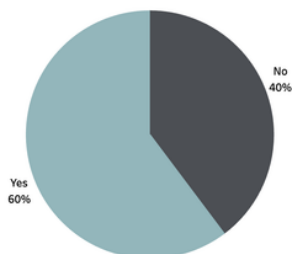


Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

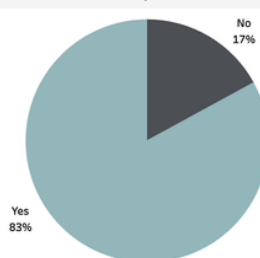
Economic Activity (continued 2/3)

- **Work Outside Music** - 60% respondents report working outside of music, with 83% of those indicating that non-music work provides their primary source of income. Respondents cite insufficient earnings from music alone (85%) as the leading reason for working outside the sector, followed by access to benefits such as health insurance and retirement (52%), flexibility to continue pursuing music (35%), and career development opportunities outside of music (35%). These responses highlight the role of external employment in sustaining long-term participation in music careers.

Work Outside of Music

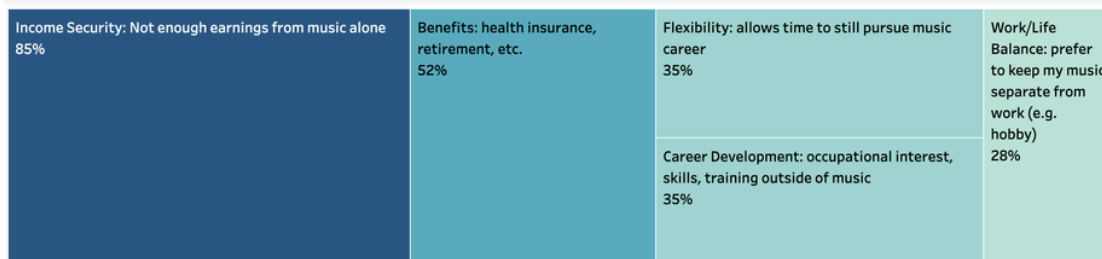


For those who work outside of music,
Outside Job Provides Primary Income



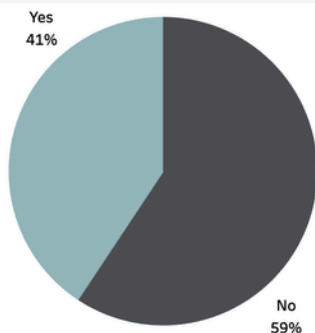
I've thought about quitting because of how difficult it is to earn a reasonable living.

Outside Work Motivation

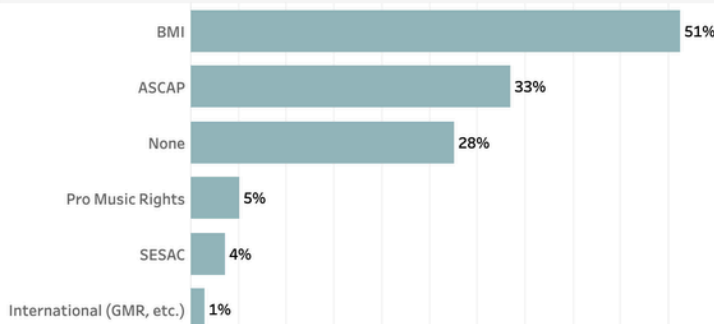


- **Publishing/Licensing** - 41% respondents report holding intellectual property rights to their music, while 59% indicate they do not. Royalty collection methods vary, with respondents most commonly reporting BMI (51%) and ASCAP (33%), while more than a quarter (28%) report not collecting royalties through any organization. Licensing activity remains limited, with 44% reporting no licensing activity, while others rely on third-party providers (30%) or publishers and rights administrators (25%), indicating uneven access to music rights infrastructure.

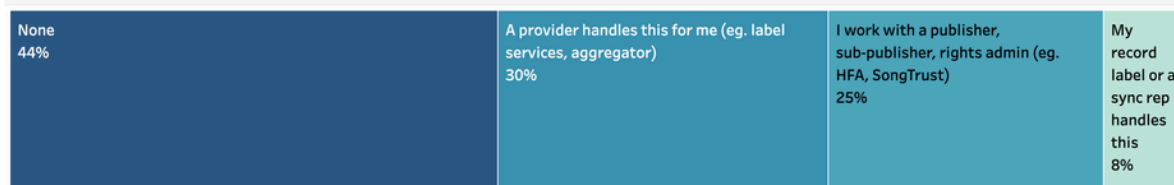
IP Rightsholder



Royalty Collection Methods



Licensing

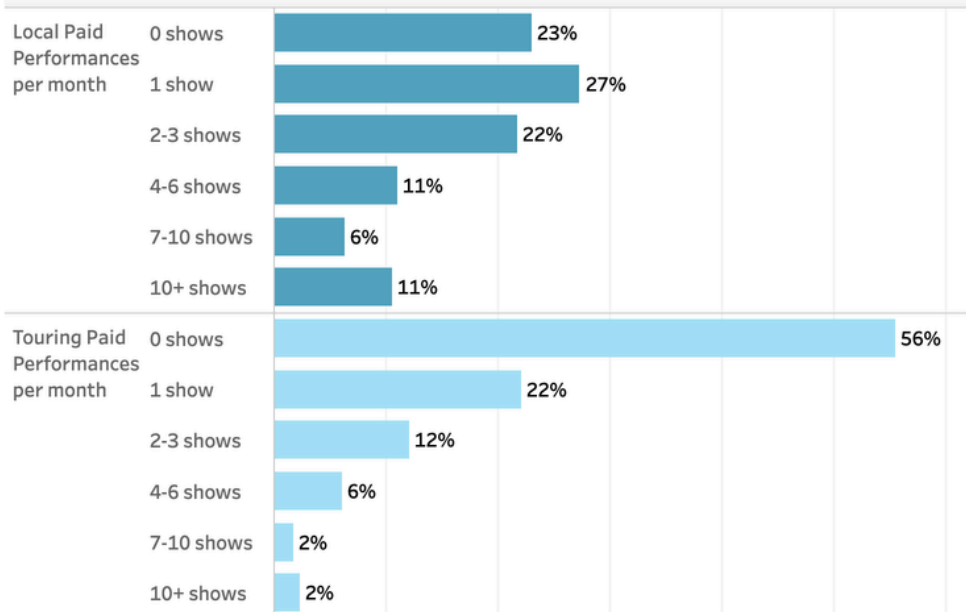


Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Economic Activity (continued 3/3)

- Creative Performance Frequency & Pay** - Local paid performance activity varies widely among respondents. While 50% report one or more paid local performances per month, nearly one-quarter (23%) report no paid local performances in a typical month. Touring activity is more limited, with 56% reporting no paid touring performances in the most recent month. As a result, while average touring pay exceeds \$300 per performance, the median touring pay is \$200, reflecting that more than half of respondents did not tour during the period reported. This reinforces the uneven and episodic nature of touring income for many Creatives.

Creative Paid Performances / Month



\$505

average pay/local gig

\$329

average pay/touring gig

\$180

median pay/local gig

\$200

median pay/touring gig

Creative Spend

\$6,667

Average Creative Spend

\$4.7M

Total Creative Respondents Spend Annually

44%

Spent Locally

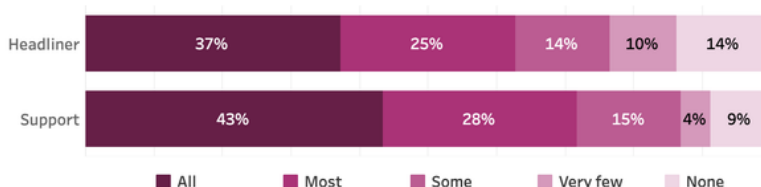
“Wages are not adequate for living expenses in the Charlotte area.”

“I have made music in this area for decades and am finally blessed with a calendar of steady gigs.”

“Teaching music pays more than performing; performing is treated like a hobby.”

- Venue Live Events and Local Talent Bookings** - Venue respondents report an average of 93 live music events per venue annually, totaling more than 5,100 live events across respondents. Local artists are regularly included in programming, with 62% of presenters reporting booking local talent as headliners for all or most events, and 71% reporting the same for support slots. These responses indicate that venues and presenters play a critical role in sustaining opportunities for local artists, even as overall performance volume and pay vary widely across the ecosystem.

Presenters Local Talent Bookings / Month



Venues average

93

live events/year

5,108

total live events/year

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Ecosystem Development

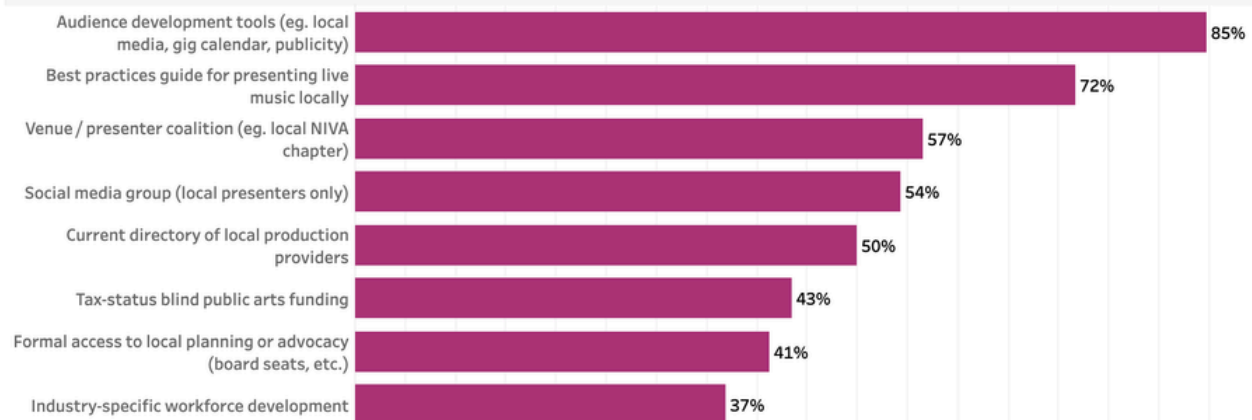
Charlotte respondents emphasize connection, collaboration, and practical support as the most important factors for strengthening the local music ecosystem. Respondents most often prioritize access to music services and industry support (57%), a place to collaborate musically (50%), and stronger connections with other creative industries (49%). Venue and Presenter respondents overwhelmingly identify audience development tools as their top business need (85%). Across the ecosystem, only 20% of respondents report having received any form of financial assistance for music-related work. Respondents primarily learn about opportunities through social media (71%) and personal networks (66%) and identify better promotion and event awareness (72%) as the most effective way to increase local audience engagement.

Local Music Resource Preference

A place to connect with music services (agency, record label, artist management, publicity, business, etc.) 57%	A place to connect with other creative industries (film/video, design, tech, gaming, etc.) 49%	Affordable rehearsal space 39%	Professional Training (music industry specific) 34%
A place to connect and collaborate musically 50%	Both virtual and in-person community networking 42%	Studio space and equipment for content creation 35%	Not needed, or already happening. 15%

- **Venue/Presenter Business Resources** - Venue/Presenter respondents emphasized practical tools to support sustainability and audience growth. Audience development tools, including local media, gig calendars, and publicity support, were prioritized by a large majority of respondents (85%). Best practices for presenting live music locally (72%) and opportunities for venue or presenter coalitions, such as a local NIVA-style chapter (57%), were also commonly cited. Social media groups for local presenters (54%) and directories of local production providers (50%) further point to demand for peer learning, shared resources, and coordinated infrastructure.

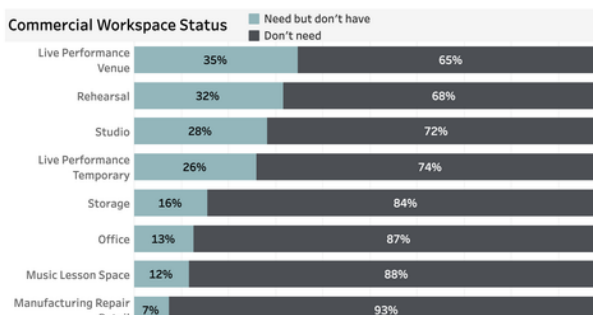
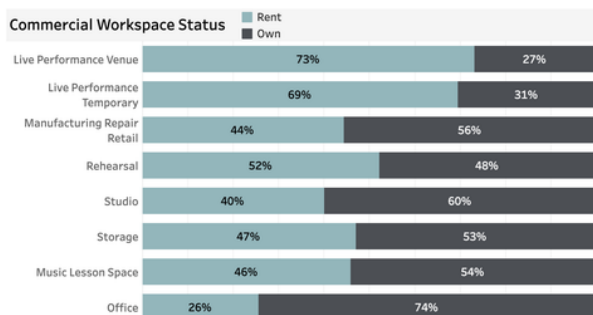
Venue/Presenters Preference for Business Resources



Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

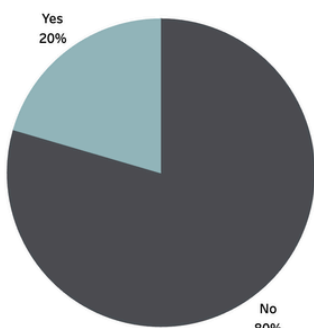
Ecosystem Development (continued 2/4)

- Commercial Workspace Status** - Charlotte respondents rely heavily on rented commercial spaces, particularly for live performance activity. Nearly three-quarters of live performance venues operate in rented facilities (73%), as do a majority of temporary performance spaces (69%). Studios, rehearsal spaces, storage, and music lesson spaces also show a relatively even split between renting and ownership. When asked about unmet workspace needs, respondents most often identified a need for live performance venues (35%), rehearsal space (32%), and studio space (28%), indicating continued pressure around access to affordable and appropriate music-related spaces.

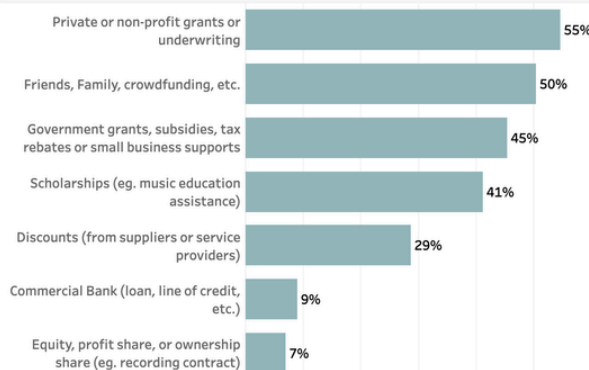


- Financial Support** - Only 20% of Charlotte respondents reported having received financial assistance for their music-related work. Among those who have accessed support, the most common sources include private or nonprofit grants or underwriting (55%), assistance from friends or family or crowdfunding (50%), and government grants or small business supports (45%). A lack of awareness of available opportunities (53%) was the most frequently cited barrier to accessing financial assistance, followed by limited grant-writing experience (19%). When asked about preferred forms of support, respondents most often favored micro-grants with less oversight (56%), tax breaks of any kind (46%), and discounted or no-cost professional services such as legal or tax preparation (39%).

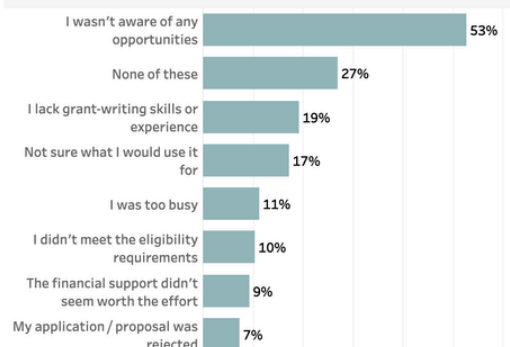
History of Financial Assistance for Music Work



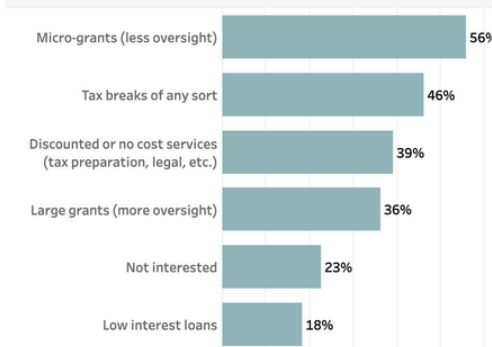
Type of Financial Assistance for Music Work



Financial Assistance Barrier



Financial Assistance Preference



There are so many grants.

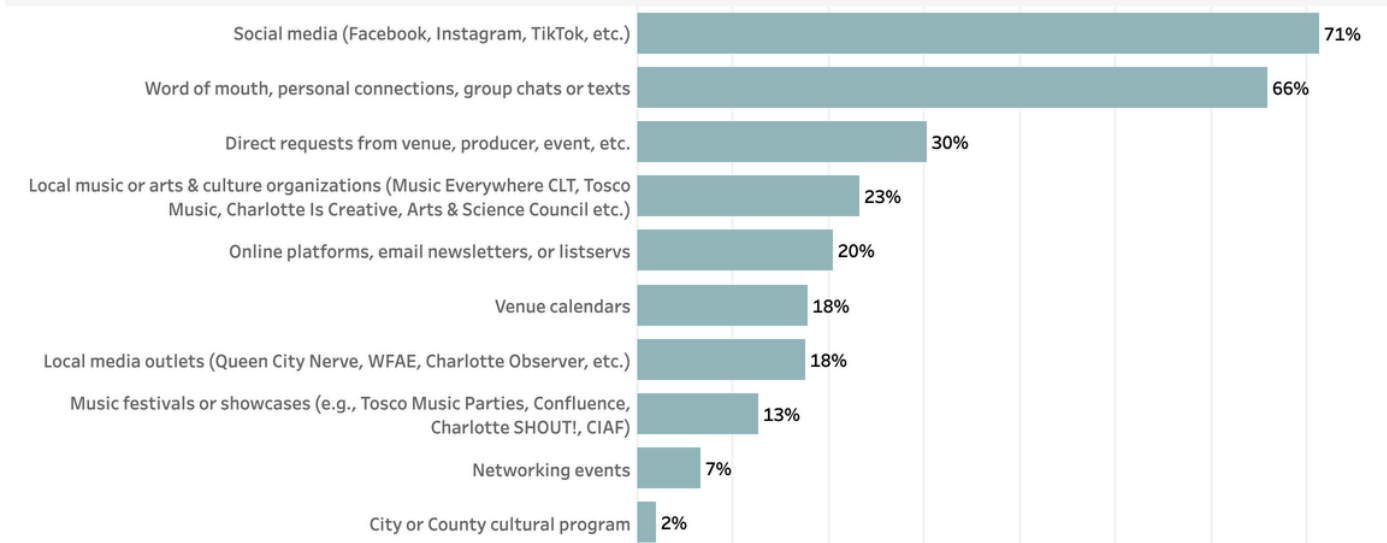
There are grants, but most people don't know about them.

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Ecosystem Development (continued 3/4)

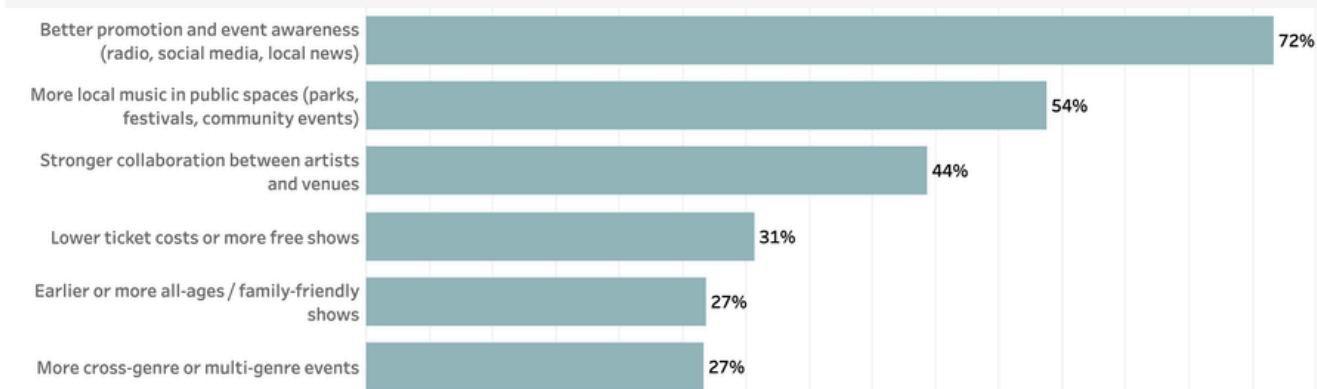
- **Information Sources for Music Opportunities** - Respondents most commonly learn about music-related opportunities through social media platforms such as Facebook, Instagram, and TikTok (71%), followed closely by word of mouth and personal networks (66%). Direct requests from venues, producers, or event organizers (30%) and information shared by local music or arts organizations (23%) play a secondary role. Traditional outlets such as venue calendars and local media were cited less frequently, suggesting opportunities to improve coordination and visibility across existing information channels.

What are your top 3 sources/platforms to find out about music opportunities (e.g., bookings, performance or teaching opportunities, collaborations, music industry services, etc.) within the Charlotte region? Select up to three choices



- **Audience Development Priorities** – Respondents identified better promotion and event awareness as the most effective way to increase local audience engagement with Charlotte’s live music scene (72%). Additional priorities include more local music in public spaces such as parks, festivals, and community events (54%) and stronger collaboration between artists and venues (44%). Lower ticket costs or more free shows (31%) and expanded all-ages or family-friendly programming (27%) were also noted, reflecting a desire to reduce barriers to attendance and broaden audience participation.

In your opinion, what would most increase local audience engagement with Charlotte’s live music scene? Select up to three choices

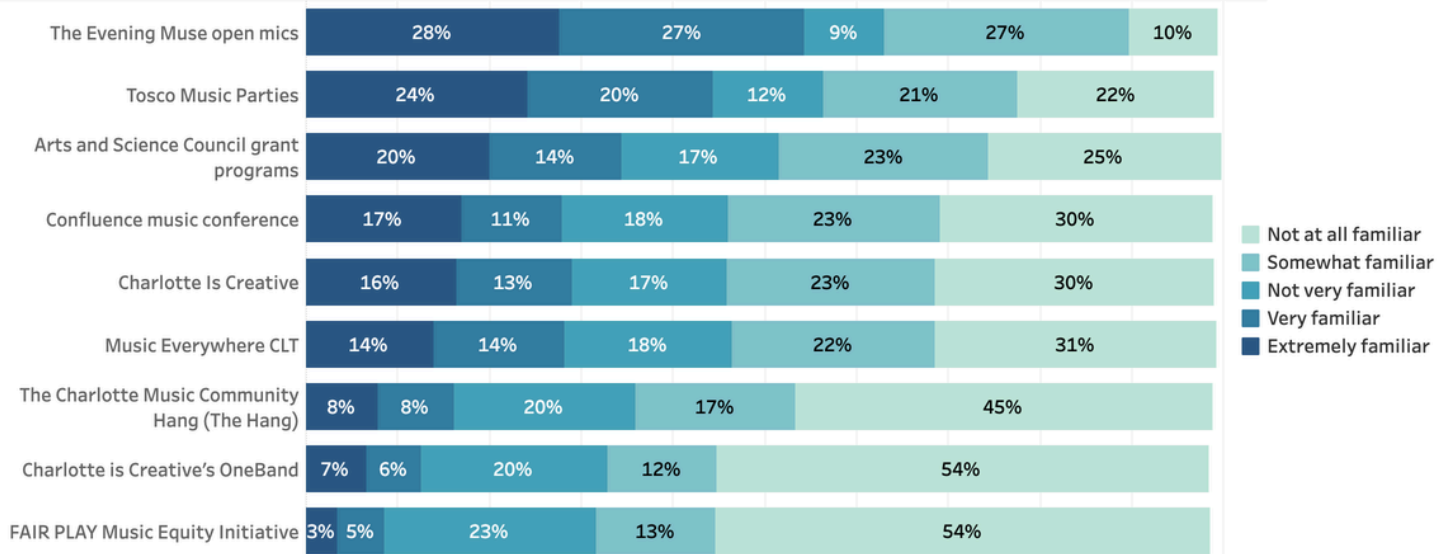


Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Ecosystem Development (continued 4/4)

- **Familiarity with Local Music Organizations and Initiatives** - Levels of familiarity with local music organizations vary widely among Charlotte respondents. For most organizations included in the survey, fewer than one in five respondents report being very familiar, while a much larger share indicate they are only somewhat familiar or not familiar at all. This pattern suggests that while Charlotte has an active landscape of music-related organizations and initiatives, awareness and visibility remain uneven across the broader music ecosystem.

How familiar are you with the following local music initiatives or organizations?



“
We're still
operating in silos.
”

“
It's hard to find
opportunities to network
unless you already know
people.
”

“
I wish there were more
casual meetups,
workshops, and
songwriter circles.
”

“
We need a dedicated hang
spot for the music
community.
”

“
Better collaboration
between musicians would
strengthen the whole
ecosystem.
”

“
Community building spaces
are missing — we don't
have a true hub.
”

“
Local journalism for music is
nonexistent.
”

“
Local major media doesn't
prioritize local music
creatives.
”

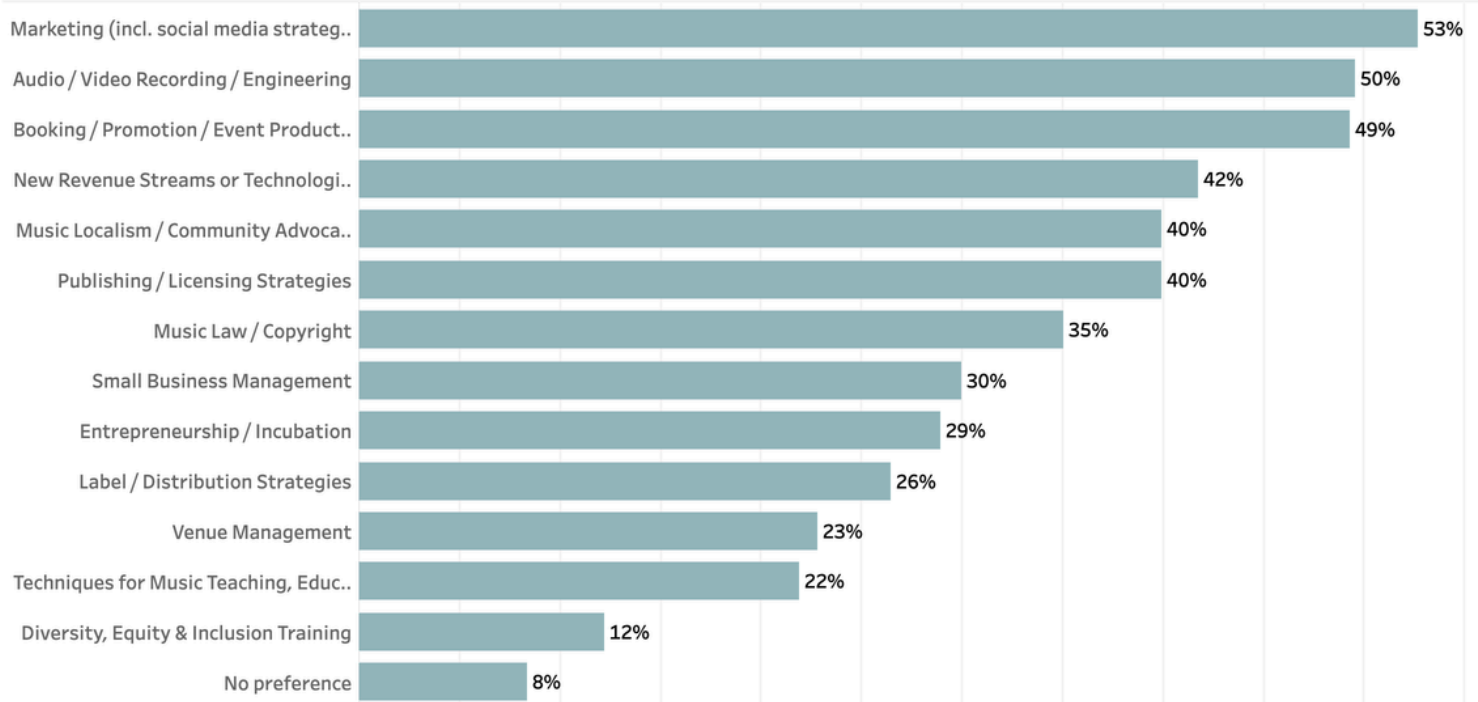
“
Even large local acts are
under supported by press
and marketing.
”

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Workforce Development

Despite the Charlotte music workforce having a strong foundation of experience, much of that experience remains informal and loosely connected to structured training pathways and professional associations. Most respondents report learning primarily through hands-on experience (56%) rather than formal education, while interest in professional development is widespread. Respondents most frequently identify marketing (53%), audio and video recording or engineering (50%), and booking, promotion, and event production (49%) as priority skill areas, pointing to demand for practical, career-sustaining workforce support.

Professional Development Training Skill Preference



- Professional Development** -Workforce development needs are primarily practical and business-oriented. Respondents most frequently identify marketing and promotion (53%), audio or video recording and engineering (50%), and booking, promotion, and event production (49%) as priority skill areas. Additional areas of interest include developing new revenue streams or technologies (42%), music localism and community advocacy (40%), publishing and licensing strategies (40%), and music law or copyright (35%).

“Marketing is the hardest part of being a musician.”

“Audio and video skills are becoming essential.”

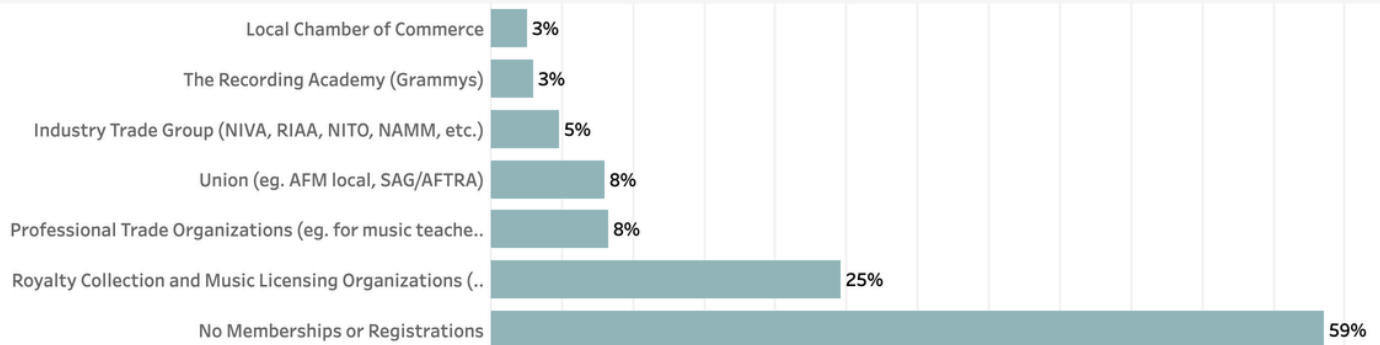
“People need help understanding the business side of music.”

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Workforce Development (continued 2/3)

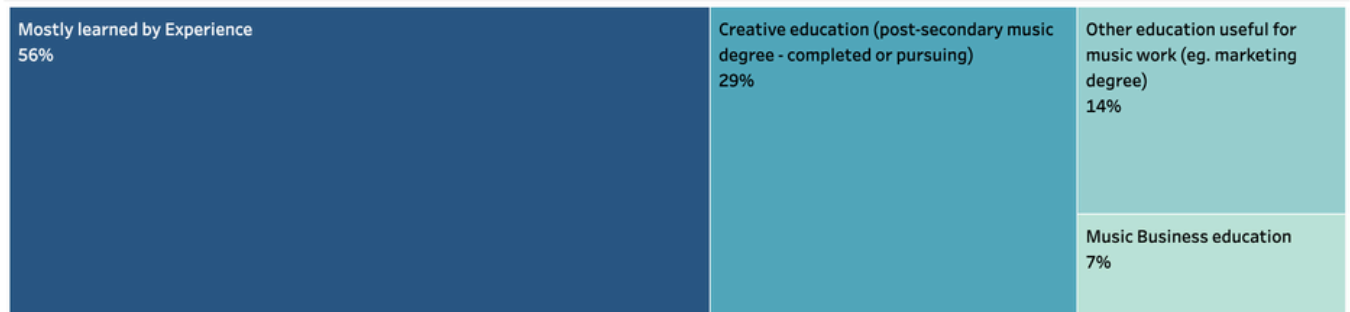
- **Professional Industry Associations** - A majority of respondents (59%) report no memberships or registrations with professional or industry organizations. Among those who do participate, royalty collection and licensing organizations are the most common (25%), followed by unions (8%), professional trade organizations (8%), and industry trade groups (5%). Participation in chambers of commerce and the Recording Academy remains limited (3% each), suggesting gaps in workforce connectivity and engagement with formal industry networks.

Registrations Memberships



- **Formal Music & Related Education** - Workforce pathways in Charlotte are largely experienced-driven. A majority of respondents (56%) report learning primarily through hands-on experience, while 29% report completing or pursuing post-secondary creative music education. An additional 14% report other education relevant to music work, such as marketing or business degrees. Only 7% report formal music business education, indicating limited access to structured, industry-specific training programs.

Formal Music Education



“There aren’t clear pathways for learning how to do this professionally.”

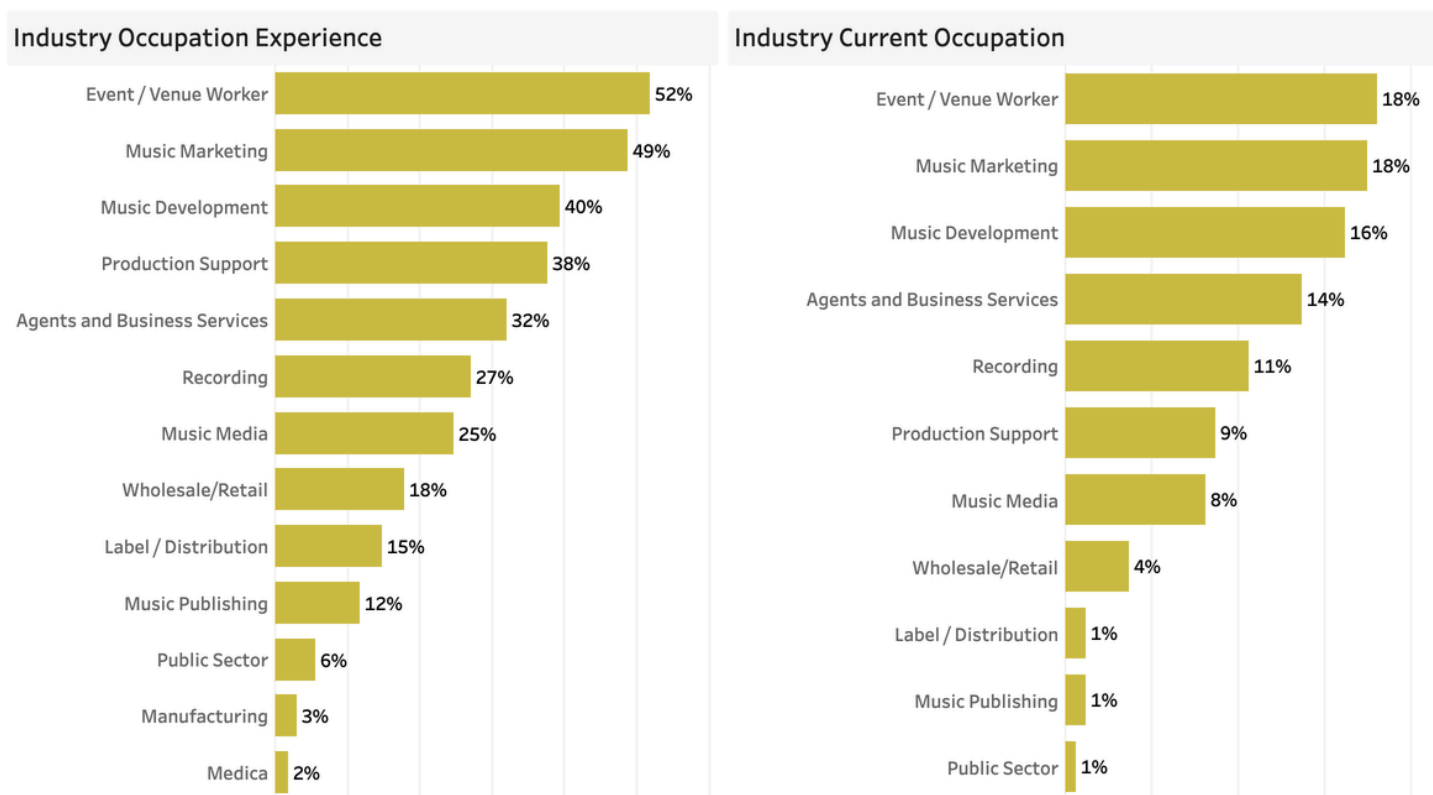
“People are self-taught because there aren’t many formal options.”

“I learned by playing gigs and figuring things out as I went.”

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Workforce Development (continued 3/3)

- Industry Occupation Experience and Current Occupation** – Respondents report experience across a broad range of music industry roles, most commonly event and venue work (52%), music marketing (49%), music development (40%), and production support (38%). However, current employment is more concentrated, with fewer respondents reporting active work in these same roles. Event and venue workers (18%) and music marketing professionals (18%) represent the most common current occupations, followed by music development (16%) and agents or business services (14%). This gap between experience and current engagement suggests an underutilized workforce and highlights opportunities to strengthen pathways between skills, training, and sustained employment.



“ Most training feels disconnected from what musicians actually need. ”

“ We need education that reflects how the industry actually works today. ”

“ There’s talent and experience that’s being wasted. ”

“ Charlotte is a good market for music education, especially for school aged kids. ”

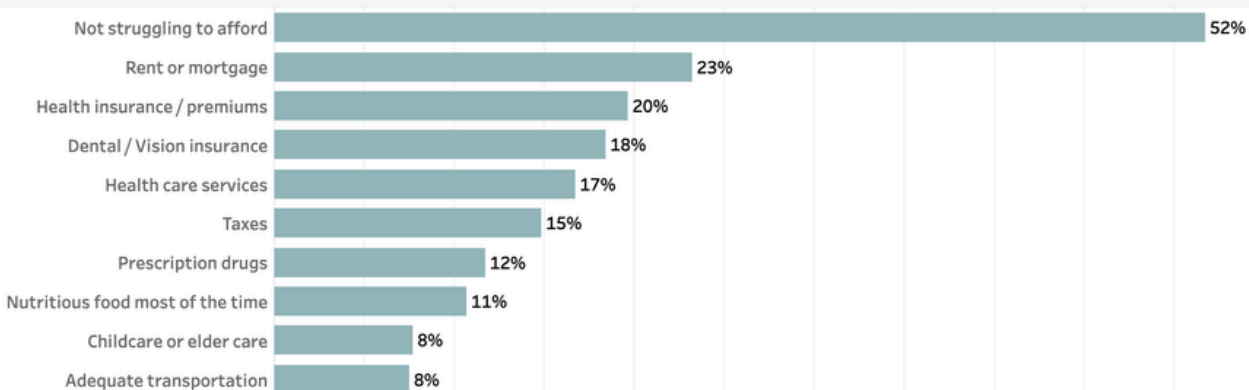
“ Teaching keeps me connected with youth and what’s more important than our children and future? ”

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Livability

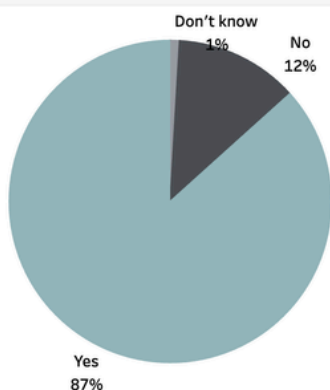
Livability pressures continue to shape sustainability across Charlotte's music ecosystem. While 52% of respondents report no current affordability struggles, 23% struggle with mortgage/rent and with health insurance premiums (20%), dental/vision insurance (18%), and with health care services (17%). Financial instability remains a central concern, with low or uncertain pay cited by 84% of respondents and lack of benefits by 62%. More than half of respondents (54%) report difficulty sustaining a long-term career in music. Most respondents report having health insurance coverage (87%), primarily through employers or public programs, pointing to a workforce that is partially supported but still economically vulnerable. For Venues and Presenters, livability challenges include fan behavior post-COVID (63%), talent costs (49%), and insurance costs (39%), reinforcing the connection between individual wellbeing, audience behavior, and business sustainability.

Affordability Struggles

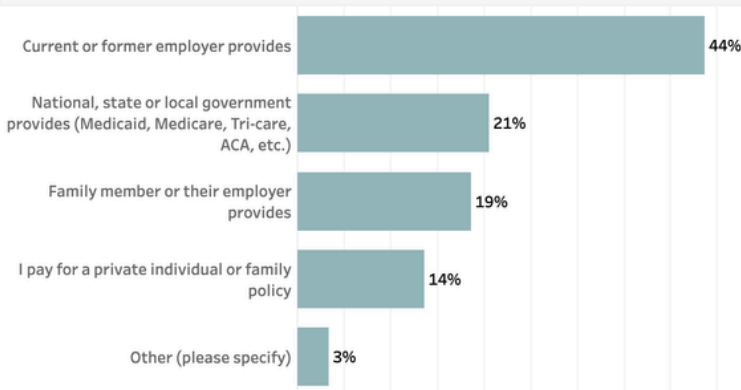


- **Health Insurance** - Most Charlotte respondents report having some form of health insurance coverage (87%). Employer-provided plans are the most common source (44%), followed by government-supported programs such as Medicaid, Medicare, or ACA plans (21%) and coverage through a family member's employer (19%). A smaller share report privately purchased plans (14%), while 12% report having no health insurance, highlighting continued vulnerability for a portion of the music workforce.

Health Insurance Coverage



Health Insurance Coverage Type



High prices.

Gentrification hurting the arts.

Cost of living makes it hard to stay.

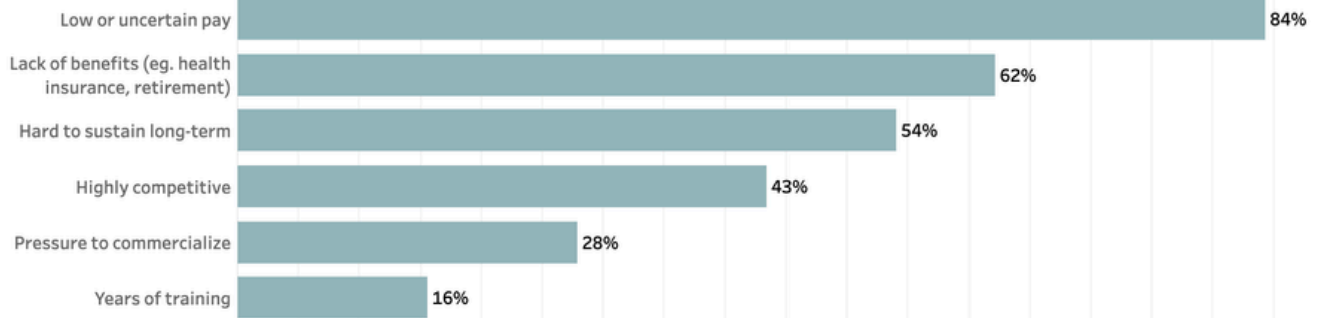
Creative spaces keep getting displaced by development.

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Livability (continued)

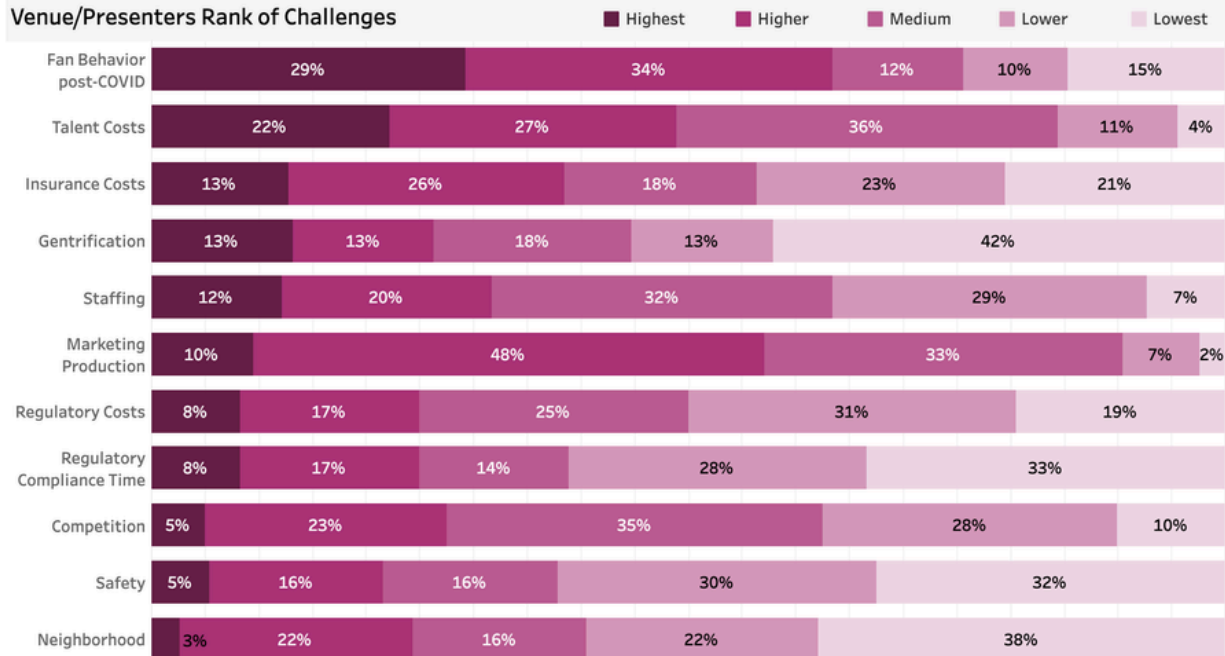
- **Music Career Challenges** – Charlotte respondents most frequently cite low or uncertain pay as the primary challenge of working in music (84%), followed by lack of benefits such as health insurance or retirement plans (62%). Difficulty sustaining a long-term career is also widespread, reported by 54% of respondents. Competitive market conditions further compound these challenges, cited by 43% of respondents, underscoring the cumulative pressures affecting income stability and career longevity.

Music Career Challenges



- **Venue/Presenters Rank of Challenges** - For venue and presenter respondents, livability challenges are reflected primarily through operational strain rather than personal affordability. Changes in fan behavior following COVID represent the most acute concern, with 29% of respondents identifying it as a highest challenge and an additional 34% ranking it as a higher challenge. Rising talent costs and insurance expenses also register as significant pressures, highlighting the interconnected relationship between audience dynamics, workforce stability, and business sustainability.

Venue/Presenters Rank of Challenges



“Rising prices push creatives out.”

“Staying long-term feels uncertain.”

“Easy to get to around the city.”

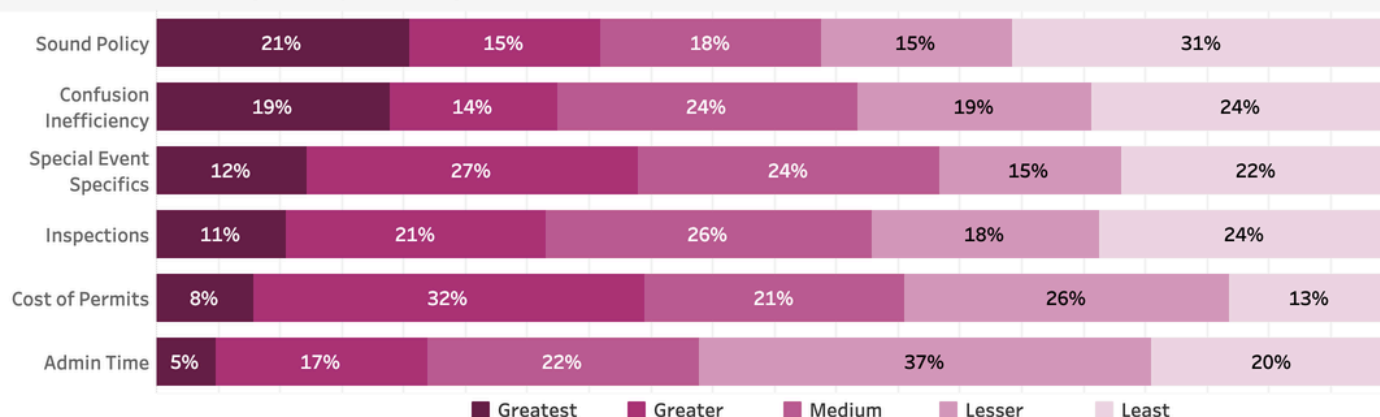
“City is too spread out; better transit needed.”

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Music-Friendly Policies

Venues/Presenters in Charlotte face a range of regulatory challenges, with sound policy ranked as the most pressing issue (21% greatest impact), followed by confusion and inefficiency (19%), special event specifics (12%), and inspections (11%). The cost of permits (8%) also contributes to operational strain for live music presenters. Respondents express strong interest in tools that make navigating city processes simpler and more transparent, led by an online permitting and communication portal (87%), followed by a webpage of current live music regulations (70%), an advocate within local government (65%), and a single point of contact for permitting (65%).

Presenters Rank of Regulatory Challenges



- Regulatory Challenges** - Venues and Presenters report sound policy as their top regulatory challenge, with 21% ranking it as having the greatest impact, followed closely by confusion and inefficiency (19% greatest). Special event specifics (12% greatest) and inspections (11% greatest) represent additional pressure points, while the cost of permits (8% greatest) further adds to administrative burden. Together, these results highlight persistent challenges related to regulatory clarity, consistency, and implementation that affect the day-to-day viability of presenting live music in Charlotte.

Live music is treated like a nuisance instead of an asset.

Sound ordinances are vague and inconsistently enforced.

It's confusing to know which permits are required.

Sound policy is unclear and constantly changing

Venues are punished even when they are trying to comply.

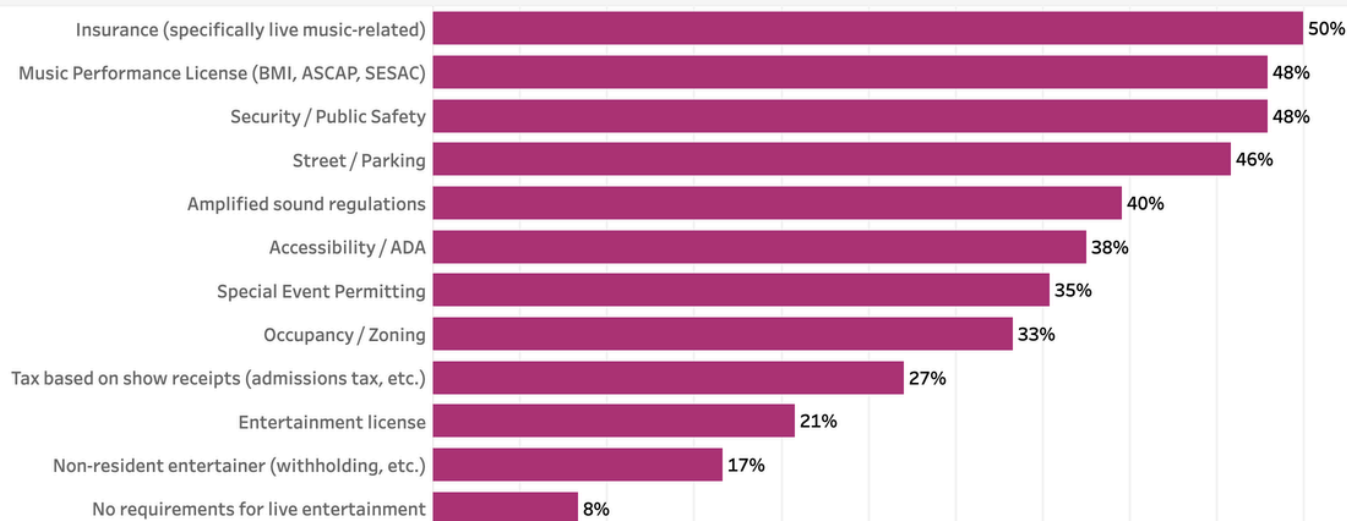
Different departments give different answers.

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Music-Friendly Policies (continued 2/3)

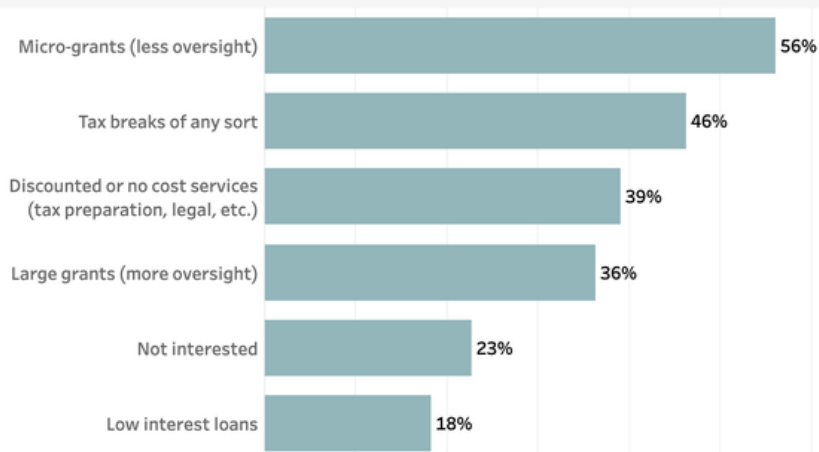
- **Regulatory Fluency** - Venue/Presenter respondents encounter multiple regulatory processes when organizing live entertainment, with insurance requirements cited most frequently (50%). Music performance licenses and security or public safety requirements each affect nearly half of respondents (48%), followed closely by street or parking regulations (46%) and amplified sound rules (40%). Accessibility requirements (38%) and special event permitting (35%) further contribute to the regulatory landscape. This breadth of required processes points to challenges in regulatory fluency rather than the presence of a single prohibitive rule.

Regulatory Processes Encountered to Present Live Entertainment



- **Financial Assistance Preferences** - When asked about financial support mechanisms, venue and presenter respondents show a clear preference for tools that reduce ongoing operating costs rather than one-time relief. Micro-grants are the most frequently cited form of support (55%), followed by tax breaks or tax-based incentives (39%). Fewer respondents prioritize traditional grants or loans, suggesting that predictable, flexible assistance tied to day-to-day operations may be more impactful than competitive or administratively intensive funding programs.

Financial Assistance Preference



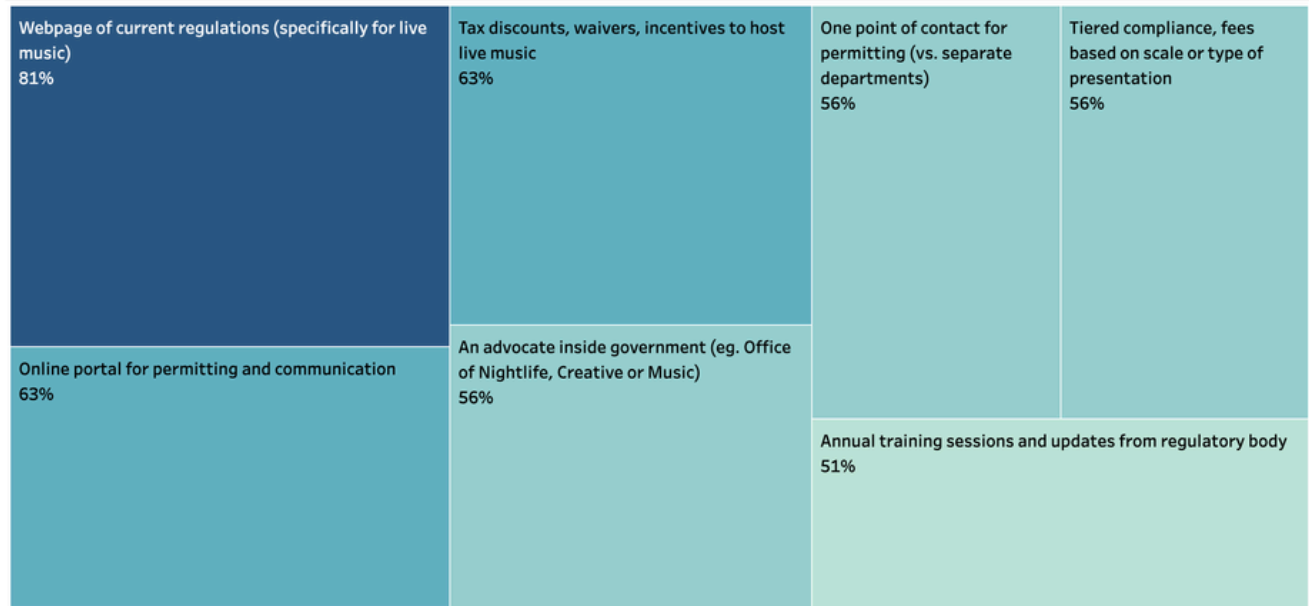
“We spend more time navigating regulations than booking shows.”

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Music-Friendly Policies (continued 3/3)

- **Venue/Presenter Tool Preference** - Respondents consistently express interest in tools that simplify and centralize interaction with city processes. A dedicated webpage outlining current live music regulations is the most desired resource (81%), followed by tax discounts or incentives to host live music (63%). Just over half of respondents favor an online permitting and communication portal (63%), a single point of contact within city government (56%), and tiered compliance or fee structures based on scale or type of presentation (56%). Annual training sessions and regulatory updates are also valued (51%), reinforcing demand for clearer guidance, transparency, and ongoing communication.

Presenters Regulatory Tools Preference



“ Clear guidelines would reduce conflict. ”

“ Rules are not clearly explained anywhere. ”

“ There’s no single place to find accurate information. ”

“ We’re expected to know rules that aren’t communicated. ”

“ Inspections feel punitive rather than supportive. ”

“ Small venues are treated the same as large events. ”

“ There’s no training on how to navigate city processes. ”

“ The city needs to be a partner, not an obstacle. ”

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Culture & Belonging

The Charlotte music ecosystem presents an overall positive picture of belonging and inclusivity with all measures leaning more positive than negative. A strong majority of respondents describe the local scene as safe (90%), non-homophobic (86%), and inclusive (82%), with many also viewing it as diverse (67%), non-sexist (66%) and cooperative (62%). Challenges include 46% describing the scene as elitist and 44% as ageist. These patterns suggest legacy barriers to entry for newcomers who may include younger or less experienced and emerging talent.

Do you find your local music scene...



Subgroup Insights

Please see the online dashboard at <https://charlottemusiccensus.org/> for full data on each indicator by subgroup. Some overarching themes to the subgroups including the following:

- Mid-career respondents (55–64) are more likely to describe the scene as ageist and elitist, pointing to barriers at both entry and advancement stages.
- Respondents identifying as Bisexual report higher levels of sexism and competitiveness.



Key Insights

- **Ecosystem Composition:** Charlotte's music ecosystem reflects a relatively healthy distribution across Creatives, Industry, and Venue/Presenter roles, consistent with patterns seen in other mature music communities, while remaining predominantly creative-led.
- **Strong Desire for Connection and Visibility:** Respondents consistently prioritize better access to music services, peer networking, and collaboration opportunities, signaling a clear appetite for stronger connective infrastructure across the local music ecosystem.
- **Economic Concerns:** Rising cost of living and pay rates not keeping pace with expenses are the most pressing concerns for Charlotte's music workforce.
- **Experienced but Narrow Pipeline:** The Charlotte music workforce is highly experienced, while participation from early-career and younger musicians remains limited.
- **Venue and Presenter Regulatory Burden:** Sound policy, regulatory confusion, and permitting processes are the most impactful challenges for venues and presenters.
- **Regional Connectivity:** Charlotte functions as part of a broader North Carolina music ecosystem, with creatives frequently working in nearby regions and neighboring states.
- **Performance Activity and Scale:** Venues and presenters report hosting more than 5,100 live music events annually, with the majority operating small- to mid-sized spaces and regularly booking local talent.
- **Creative Economic Contribution:** Creative respondents report spending an estimated \$4.7 million annually on their music careers, with nearly half of those expenses paid locally.
- **Income Stability and Support Gaps:** Music-related income represents a limited share of total earnings for many respondents, with most relying on non-music work and only one in five having accessed financial assistance.
- **Underutilized Skills and Training Demand:** Respondents report deep experience across key music industry roles alongside strong demand for practical professional development, particularly in marketing and promotion, booking and event production, and audio and video recording or engineering.
- **Workspace Constraints:** A majority of live music venues and temporary performance spaces operate in rented facilities, with ongoing unmet needs for performance, rehearsal, and studio space.
- **Culture and Belonging:** Charlotte's music ecosystem is experienced as overwhelmingly positive on all fronts, with some challenges around elitism and ageism.



Photos Courtesy of Music Everywhere Charlotte

Community Action Opportunities

- 1 **Strengthen Connections and Help the Music Community Navigate the Scene:** Support recurring, cross-sector gatherings and shared communication tools that help musicians, venues, and industry professionals see opportunities and connect more easily. Strengthening informal networks reduces fragmentation and makes collaboration and resource-sharing easier across the local music ecosystem.
- 2 **Develop Leaders in Charlotte Music Program:** Develop a cohort-based leadership program, in partnership with community organizations, that brings together emerging and mid-career leaders across creative, venue, and industry sectors to strengthen cross-sector collaboration, build trusted connectors, and support community-driven solutions that expand long-term opportunity for Charlotte's music ecosystem.
- 3 **Expand Practical Professional Development and Skill Building:** Offer accessible, hands-on workshops focused on real-world music business skills such as booking, promotion, event production, marketing, and new revenue opportunities, delivered through collaborative partnerships and tailored to different career stages.
- 4 **Improve Audience Development and Music Visibility:** Strengthen how local music is discovered and promoted through media partnerships, storytelling initiatives, a centralized music calendar, shared promotional tools, and best-practice guidance to help venues and presenters build audiences more consistently.
- 5 **Streamline Regulatory Processes and Improve Fluency:** Work with city departments to simplify rules around live music, including permitting, sound policies, and event approvals, supported by clear, centralized information and regular education efforts to reduce confusion and administrative burden.
- 6 **Connect Experience with the Next Generation Through Mentorship:** Create mentorship opportunities pairing experienced professionals with emerging creatives and industry workers to support knowledge transfer, strengthen career pathways, and retain institutional knowledge.
- 7 **Expand Access to Financial Assistance and Economic Tools:** Increase awareness of existing funding while exploring accessible options such as micro-grants, incentives, or fee relief for creatives and venues, prioritizing simple processes and clear communication.
- 8 **Support Inclusive and Cross-Genre Programming:** Encourage programming that brings together diverse genres, backgrounds, and communities, helping reduce silos and strengthen culture, belonging, and collaboration within the ecosystem.
- 9 **Strengthen Regional Collaboration and Exchange:** Support regional partnerships through shared programming, touring opportunities, and cross-promotion with nearby markets to expand opportunities for Charlotte artists while helping more value stay in the local music economy.
- 10 **Expand Affordable Workspace, Rehearsal, and Shared-Use Solutions:** Encourage flexible, shared-use solutions for rehearsal, recording, and performance space through partnerships with existing and nontraditional venues, expanding access without requiring major new construction.